CHESS HANDOUTS

SERGEY V. POPOV

EXPERT

26 lessons · 156 puzzles from master games · Solutions on page 53

Name: _____ **Club / group:** _____

Colour Key

Strategy
Pawn structures, pieces and plans

Openings
Two openings that use the plans

Attack
Pawn storms and classic sacrifices

Endgame
Theory every expert should know

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Examples and puzzles from published master games (game scores are factual records); positions checked with Stockfish. Chess pieces: Noto Sans Symbols 2 (SIL Open Font License).

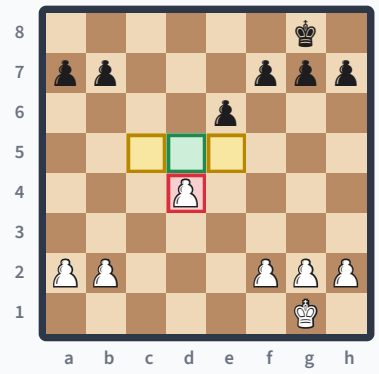
THE ISOLATED QUEEN'S PAWN

Dynamic strength now, static weakness later

Lesson 1 · Strategy
Level 4 Strategy

1. The IQP Structure

NO C- OR E-PAWN

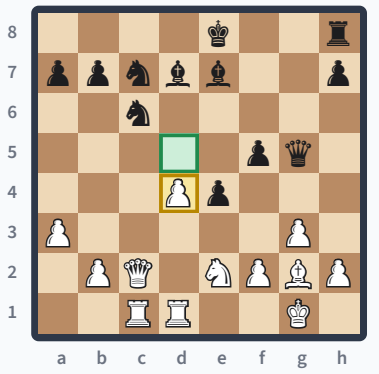


`d4 alone · d5 is the blockade square`

- No pawn can ever defend **d4**, and **d5** in front of it is a perfect square for a blockading Knight.
- In return the IQP side gets open c- and e-files, outposts on **e5** and **c5**, and more space for attack.

2. Portisch–Ljubojevic

IQP

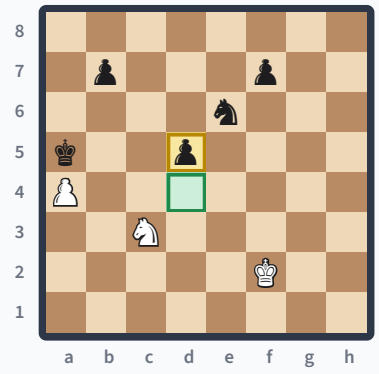


`24.d5 Ne5 25.Qxc7`

- White has the isolated d-pawn: play actively, before the endgame comes.
- **24.d5!** 24...Ne5 25.Qxc7, winning 3 points.
- Portisch v Ljubojevic, Linares 1990

3. Ivanchuk–Gelfand

IQP

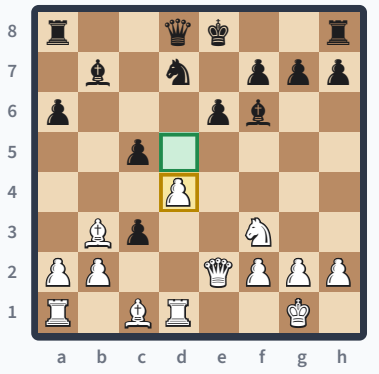


`43...d4 44.Nb5 Kxa4`

- Black has the isolated d-pawn: play actively, before the endgame comes.
- **43...d4!** 44.Nb5 Kxa4, winning 1 point.
- Ivanchuk v Gelfand, TCh-RUS 2005

4. Smyslov–Keres: 14.d5!

IQP



`14.d5 cxb2 15.Bxb2`

- White has the isolated d-pawn: play actively, before the endgame comes.
- **14.d5!** 14...cxb2 15.Bxb2: White is clearly better (engine +1.6).
- Smyslov v Keres, Candidats Tournament 1953

Playing With and Against the IQP

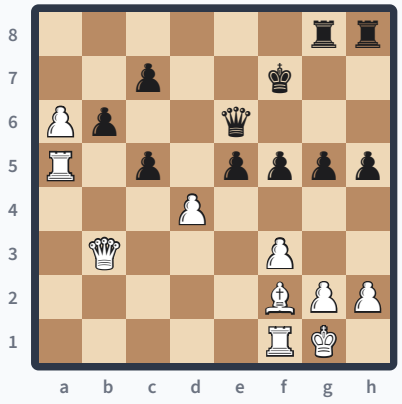
1. **With the IQP:** keep pieces on, put a Knight on e5, aim at the King, and look for the **d4-d5 break**.
2. **Against it:** blockade on d5 (a Knight is best), trade minor pieces, then pile up on the pawn.
3. Every exchange helps the side playing against the IQP: in the endgame the pawn is just weak.

PUZZLES: THE ISOLATED QUEEN'S PAWN

Six positions from master games

Lesson 1 · Strategy Puzzles
Level 4 Strategy

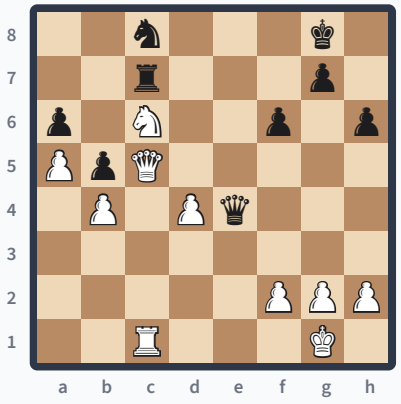
1 Find the best move for White!



Alekhine v Lasker
Paris mt 1913

Answer:

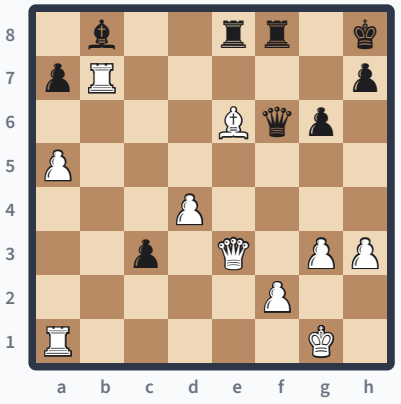
2 Find the best move for White!



Euwe v Alekhine
Zuerich 1934

Answer:

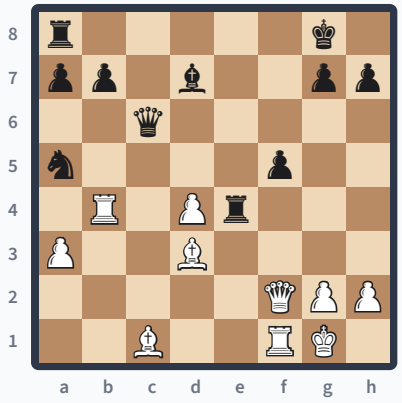
3 Find the best move for White!



Anand v Shirov
SuperGM 2000

Answer:

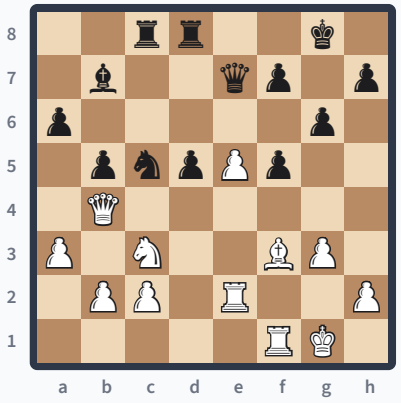
4 Find the best move for White!



Petrosian v Ljubojevic
Niksic 1983

Answer:

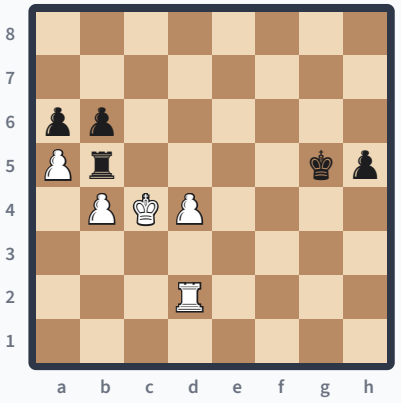
5 Find the best move for Black!



Steinitz v Bird
London m2 1866

Answer:

6 Find the best move for White!



Bronstein v Bernstein
FRA-URS 1954

Answer:

Tip: first find the plan for this structure, then check the tactics that serve it.

Score: ____ / 6

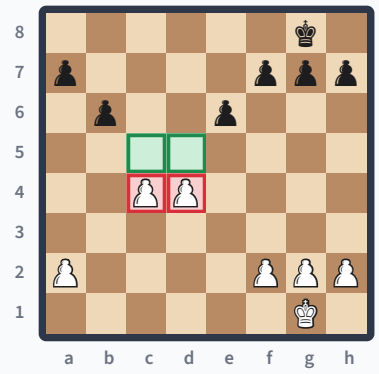
HANGING PAWNS

Two pawns side by side on c4 and d4, with no neighbours

Lesson 2 · Strategy
Level 4 Strategy

1. The Structure

C + D, NO B- OR E-PAWN

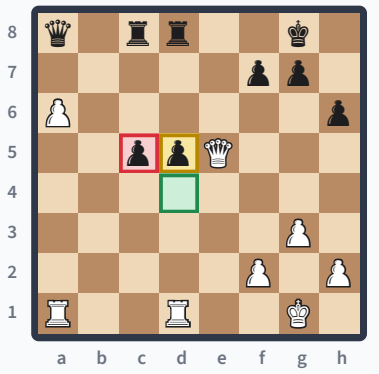


`c4 + d4 side by side`

- Side by side, **c4 and d4** control b5, c5, d5 and e5: lots of space and two half-open files for the opponent.
- If one pawn is forced forward, the other becomes backward or isolated, and the square in front (**c5** or **d5**) is lost.

2. Anand–Adams: 31...d4!

HANGING PAWNS

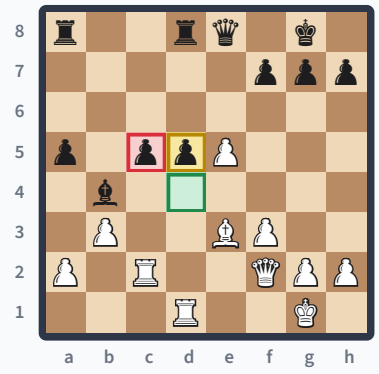


`31...d4 32.Ra3 Qa7`

- Black has the hanging pawns: keep them side by side and push one at the right moment.
- **31...d4!** 32.Ra3 Qa7: Black is clearly better (engine +2.2).
- Anand v Adams, XXII SuperGM 2005

3. Botvinnik–Euwe: 26...d4!

HANGING PAWNS

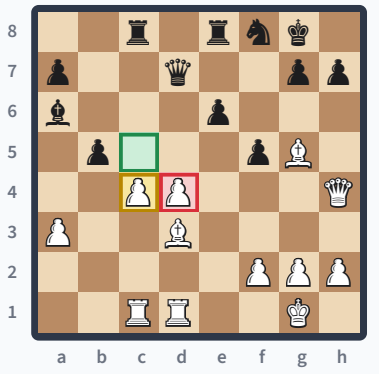


`26...d4 27.Bg5 Rd5`

- Black has the hanging pawns: keep them side by side and push one at the right moment.
- **26...d4!** 27.Bg5 Rd5: Black is clearly better (engine +1.6).
- Botvinnik v Euwe, Leningrad 1934

4. Boleslavsky–Botvinnik

HANGING PAWNS



`22.c5 Bb7 23.Qg3`

- White has the hanging pawns: keep them side by side and push one at the right moment.
- **22.c5!** 22...Bb7 23.Qg3: White is clearly better (engine +1.5).
- Boleslavsky v Botvinnik, Leningrad/Moscow 1941

Hanging Pawns: Strong or Weak?

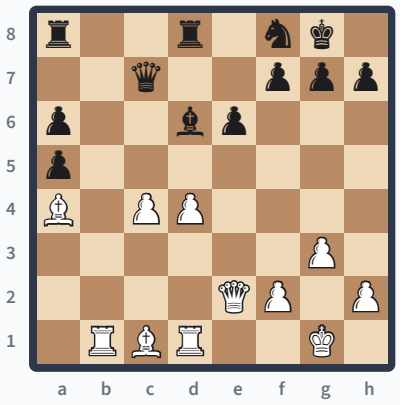
1. **Owner:** keep the pawns abreast and use the space; the push **d4-d5** (or c4-c5) is the key break, but only when it gains something.
2. **Opponent:** attack them with pieces (Rooks on c- and d-files, a Bishop on the long diagonal) and with pawn levers such as ...e5 or ...b5.
3. Advanced too early, they become a weak isolated pawn plus a hole. Timing is everything.

PUZZLES: HANGING PAWNS

Six positions from master games

Lesson 2 · Strategy Puzzles
Level 4 Strategy

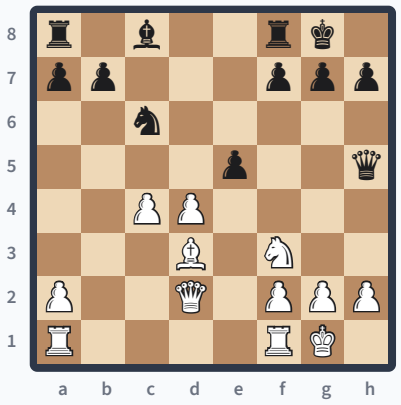
1 Find the best move for White!



Schlechter v Chigorin
London 1899

Answer:

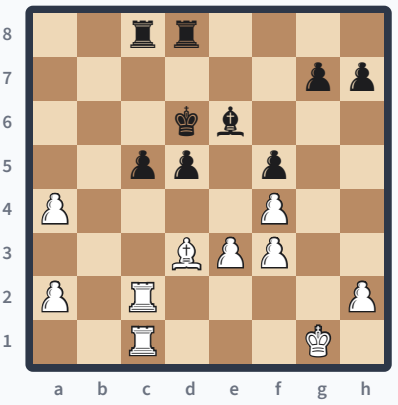
2 Find the best move for White!



Schlechter v Marshall
Ostende 1907

Answer:

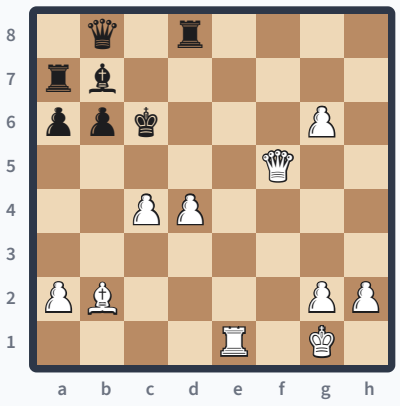
3 Find the best move for Black!



Tartakower v Rubinstein
Karlsbad 1923

Answer:

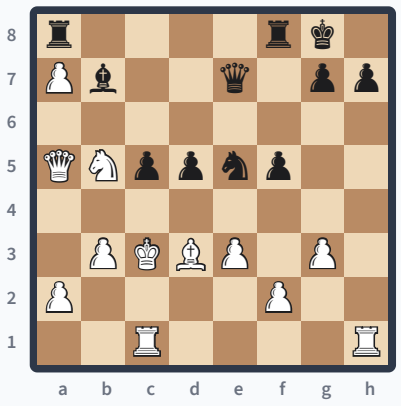
4 Find the best move for White!



Botvinnik v Chekhover
Moscow 1935

Answer:

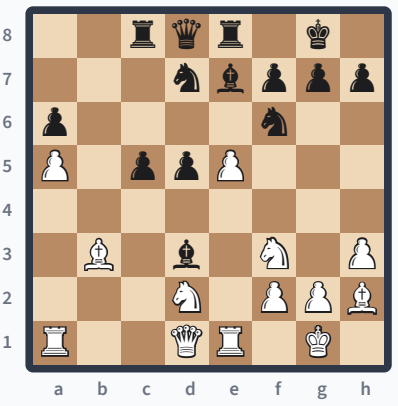
5 Find the best move for Black!



Vachier Lagrave v Caruana
2nd Sinquefield Cup 2014

Answer:

6 Find the best move for Black!



Nakamura v Nepomniachtchi
FIDE World Cup 2015

Answer:

Tip: first find the plan for this structure, then check the tactics that serve it.

Score: ____ / 6

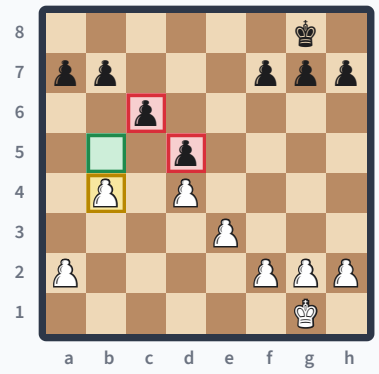
THE MINORITY ATTACK

Carlsbad structure: two pawns attack three

Lesson 3 · Strategy
Level 4 Strategy

1. The Carlsbad Structure

QGD EXCHANGE

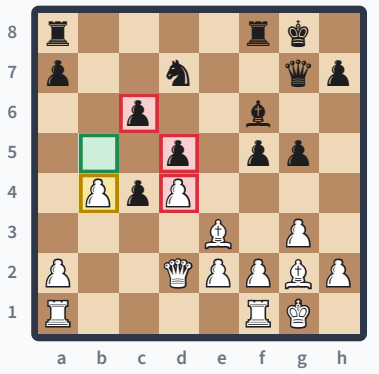


`White: a2 b2 d4 e3 · Black: a7 b7 c6 d5`

- After cxd5 exd5, White has 2 pawns against 3 on the queenside. The plan: **b4-b5**, then bxc6.
- Whatever Black does, a weak pawn appears: a backward **c6**-pawn or an isolated **d5**-pawn.

2. Sliwa–Smyslov: 22.b5!

CARLSBAD

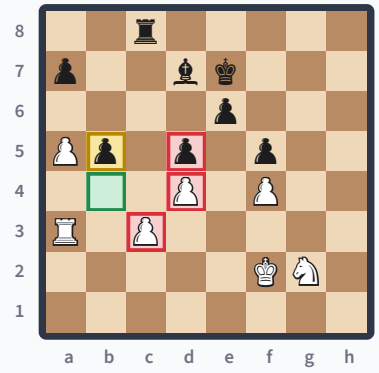


`22.b5 Nb6 23.bxc6`

- White has the Carlsbad structure with the minority attack plan: b4-b5 to break up the queenside.
- **22.b5!** 22...Nb6 23.bxc6, winning 1 point.
- Sliwa v Smyslov, Alekhine mem 1956

3. Chigorin–Mason: 47...b4!

CARLSBAD

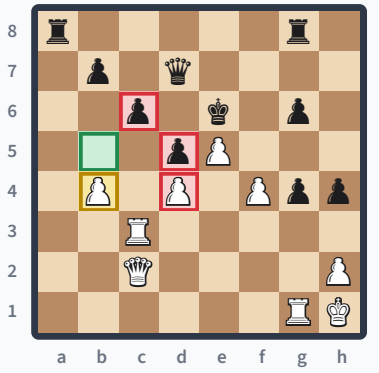


`47...b4 48.cxb4 Rc2+`

- Black has the Carlsbad structure with the minority attack plan: b4-b5 to break up the queenside.
- **47...b4!** 48.cxb4 Rc2+: Black is clearly better (engine +2.2).
- Chigorin v Mason, London+ 1883

4. Caruana–Garcia Palermo

CARLSBAD



`29.b5 Qf7 30.bxc6`

- White has the Carlsbad structure with the minority attack plan: b4-b5 to break up the queenside.
- **29.b5!** 29...Qf7 30.bxc6, winning 1 point.
- Caruana v Garcia Palermo, 66th ch-ITA 2006

How the Minority Attack Works

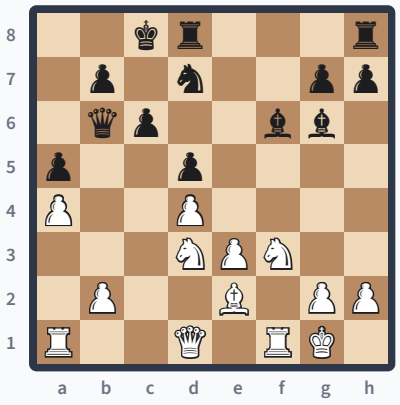
1. Put Rooks on the b- and c-files, push **b4-b5**, and take on c6 to leave Black with a weak pawn.
2. Black's answers: a kingside attack (Knight to e4, ...f5) or the central break **...c5**.
3. The minority attack works best with the centre closed and Black's pieces far from the queenside.

PUZZLES: THE MINORITY ATTACK

Six positions from master games

Lesson 3 · Strategy Puzzles
Level 4 Strategy

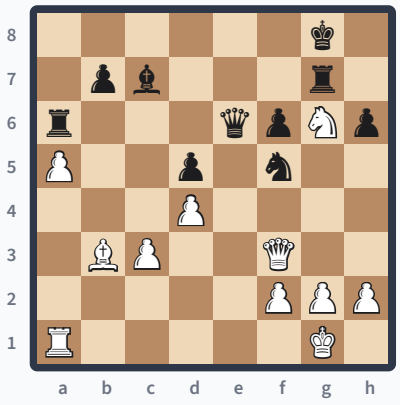
1 Find the best move for White!



Gelfand v Kacheishvili
ECC 2003

Answer:

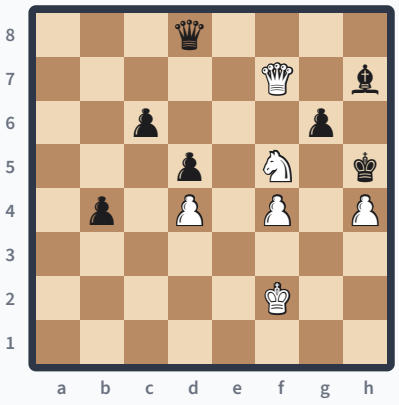
2 Find the best move for Black!



Bird v Zukertort
Vienna 1882

Answer:

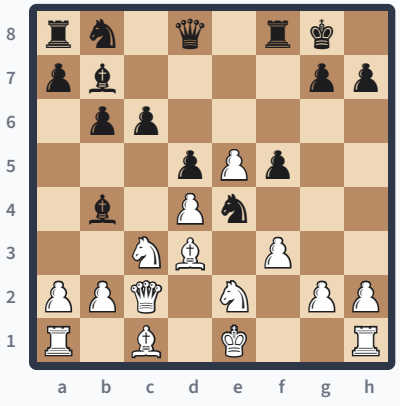
3 Find the best move for White!



Beliavsky v Portisch
World Cup 1988

Answer:

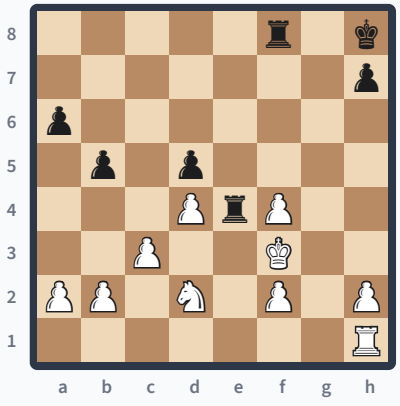
4 Find the best move for White!



Tartakower v Marshall
Bad Kissingen 1928

Answer:

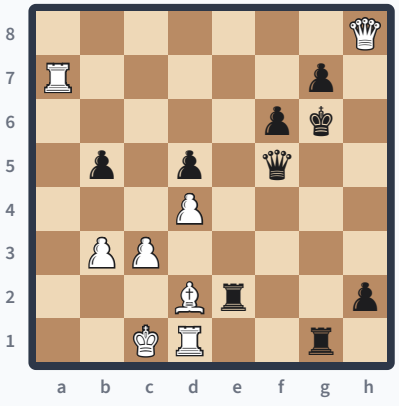
5 Find the best move for Black!



Topalov v Adams
Bosna SuperGM 2000

Answer:

6 Find the best move for Black!



Shabalov v Aronian
36th Olympiad 2004

Answer:

Tip: first find the plan for this structure, then check the tactics that serve it.

Score: ____ / 6

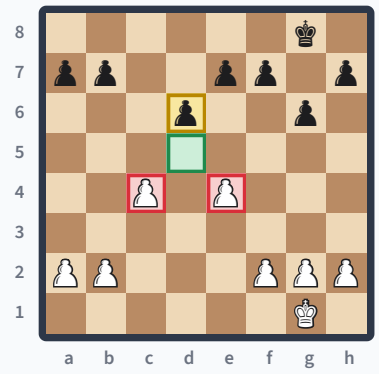
THE MAROCZY BIND

Pawns on c4 and e4 clamp the d5-square

Lesson 4 · Strategy
Level 4 Strategy

1. The Bind

C4 + E4 VS D6

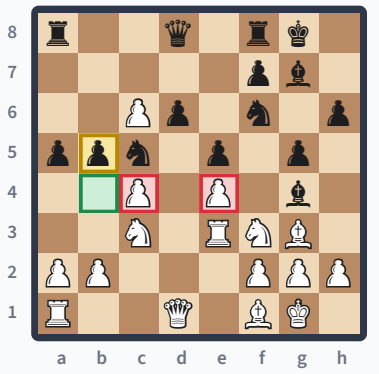


`Sicilian: no white d-pawn, no black c-pawn`

- White's pawns on **c4** and **e4** control d5, so Black's natural freeing move **...d5** is very hard to achieve.
- Black waits for **...b5** or **...f5**, and often trades pieces to relieve the cramp.

2. Petrosian–Spassky

MAROCZY BIND

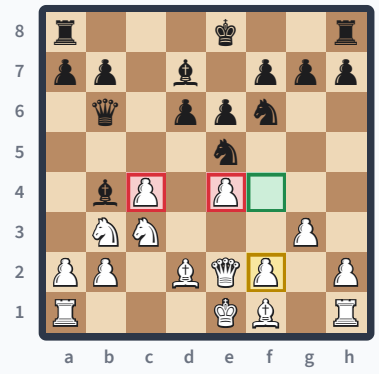


`15...b4 16.Nd5 Nfxe4`

- Black is in the Maroczy Bind: look for the breaks ...b5, ...d5 or ...f5.
- **15...b4!** 16.Nd5 Nfxe4: Black keeps an edge (engine +0.5).
- Petrosian v Spassky, URS-ch27 1960

3. Gelfand–Nepomniachtchi

MAROCZY BIND

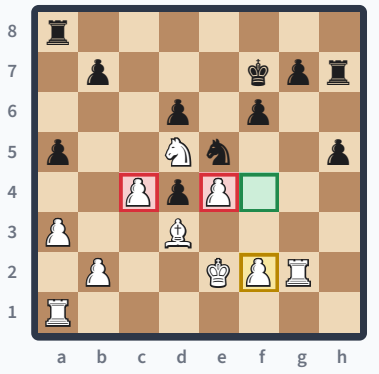


`11.f4 Ng6 12.e5`

- White has the Maroczy Bind: keep the clamp on d5 and stop the freeing breaks.
- **11.f4!** 11...Ng6 12.e5: White keeps an edge (engine +0.9).
- Gelfand v Nepomniachtchi, Jerusalem FIDE Grand Prix 2019

4. Bogoljubow–Reti: 25.f4!

MAROCZY BIND



`25.f4 Nxd3 26.Kxd3`

- White has the Maroczy Bind: keep the clamp on d5 and stop the freeing breaks.
- **25.f4!** 25...Nxd3 26.Kxd3: White is winning (engine +5.0).
- Bogoljubow v Reti, Kiel 1921

Living in the Bind

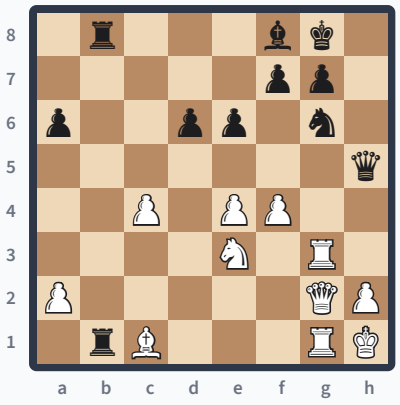
1. **White:** keep d5 under control, avoid exchanges that free Black, and prepare to expand on the queenside (b4, c5).
2. **Black:** the Knight on c5 or e5 and the g7-Bishop are your best pieces. Prepare ...a5/...b5 or ...f5 carefully.
3. One freeing break at the right moment can turn a passive position into a good one.

PUZZLES: THE MAROCZY BIND

Six positions from master games

Lesson 4 · Strategy Puzzles
Level 4 Strategy

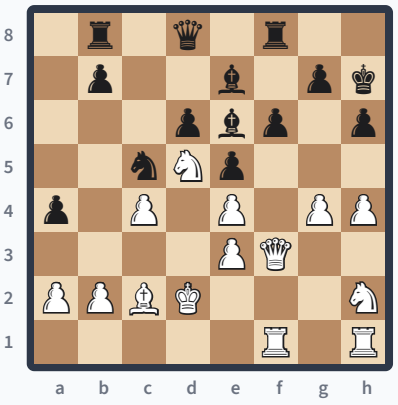
1 Find the best move for White!



Kortschnoj v Portisch
Candidats qf1 1983

Answer:

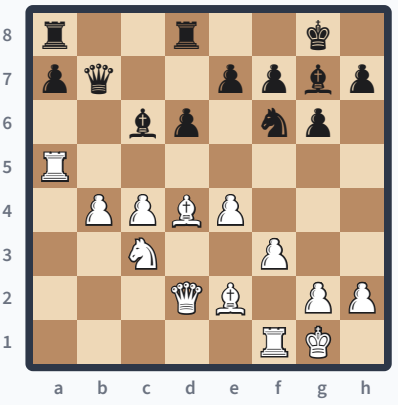
2 Find the best move for Black!



NN v Lasker
Amsterdam 1889

Answer:

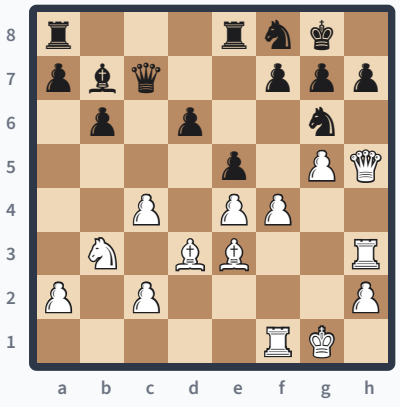
3 Find the best move for White!



Andersson v Schunk
Bundesliga 2005-6

Answer:

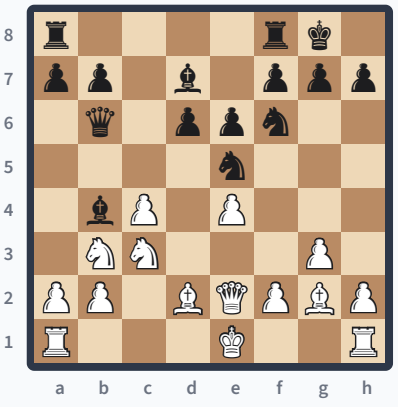
4 Find the best move for White!



Caruana v Pengxiang
II Ruy Lopez Masters 2008

Answer:

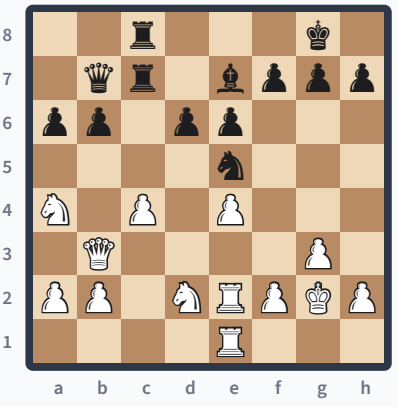
5 Find the best move for White!



Caruana v So
8th Sinquefield Cup 2021

Answer:

6 Find the best move for Black!



Wade v Keres
Tallinn 1971

Answer:

Tip: first find the plan for this structure, then check the tactics that serve it.

Score: ____ / 6

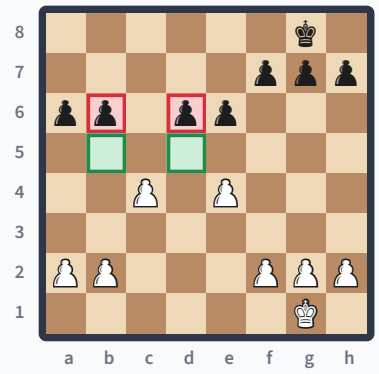
THE HEDGEHOG

Cramped but full of spikes

Lesson 5 · Strategy
Level 4 Strategy

1. The Spikes

A6 B6 D6 E6

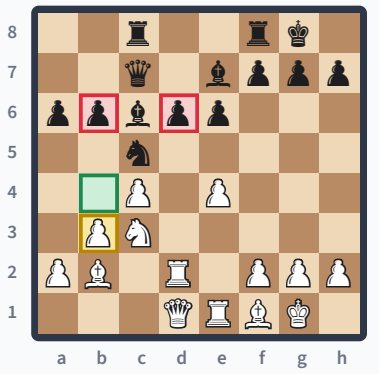


`Black pawns on the 6th rank`

- Black keeps pawns on **a6, b6, d6, e6**: no space, but no weaknesses either, and every piece is ready.
- When White over-extends, the breaks **...b5** and **...d5** open the position with force.

2. Geller–Popov: 17.b4!

HEDGEHOG

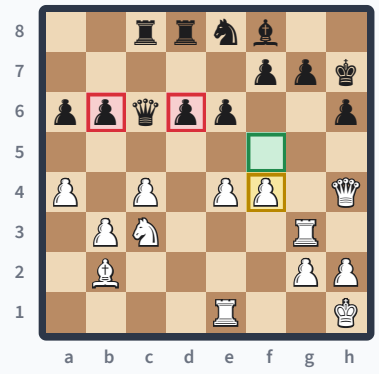


`17.b4 Nd7 18.Nd5`

- White faces the Hedgehog: use the extra space, but watch the ...b5 and ...d5 breaks.
- **17.b4!** 17...Nd7 18.Nd5: White is clearly better (engine +1.9).
- Geller v Popov, Skopje 1967

3. Barua–Topalov: 25.f5!

HEDGEHOG

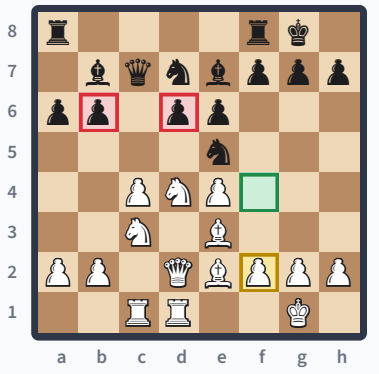


`25.f5 Qd7 26.fxe6`

- White faces the Hedgehog: use the extra space, but watch the ...b5 and ...d5 breaks.
- **25.f5!** 25...Qd7 26.fxe6: White is clearly better (engine +2.6).
- Barua v Topalov, Biel Interzonal 1993

4. Grischuk–Zaitsev: 15.f4!

HEDGEHOG



`15.f4 Ng6 16.f5`

- White faces the Hedgehog: use the extra space, but watch the ...b5 and ...d5 breaks.
- **15.f4!** 15...Ng6 16.f5: White is clearly better (engine +2.7).
- Grischuk v Zaitsev, Moscow op2 1995

Hedgehog Rules

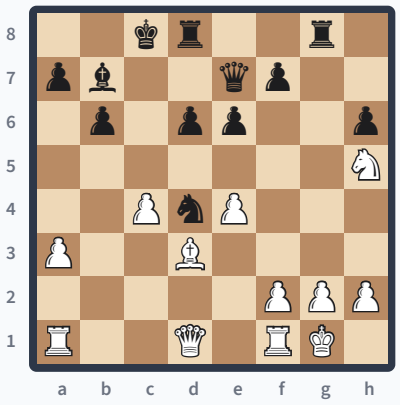
1. **Black:** be patient. Regroup (Bf8, Rc8, Qb8) and only break with ...b5 or ...d5 when tactics work.
2. **White:** keep control of b5 and d5; a slow build-up (f4, g4) can work, but every pawn move leaves holes.
3. The side that breaks at the right moment usually wins the Hedgehog battle.

PUZZLES: THE HEDGEHOG

Six positions from master games

Lesson 5 · Strategy Puzzles
Level 4 Strategy

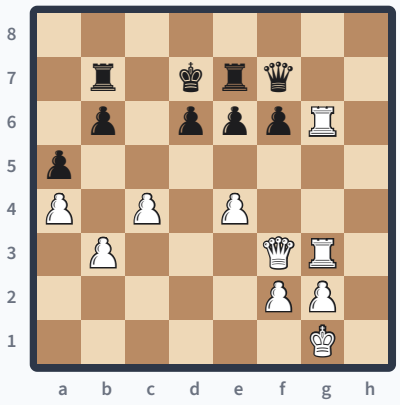
1 Find the best move for Black!



Geller v Spassky
URS-ch22 1955

Answer:

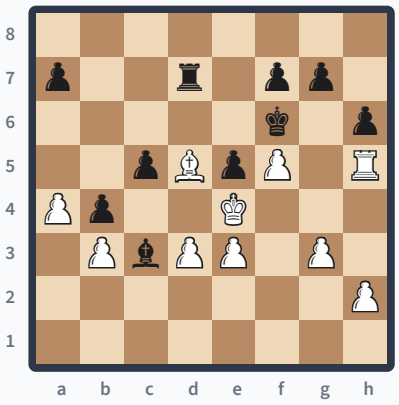
2 Find the best move for White!



Larsen v Sorensen
DEN-ch 1989

Answer:

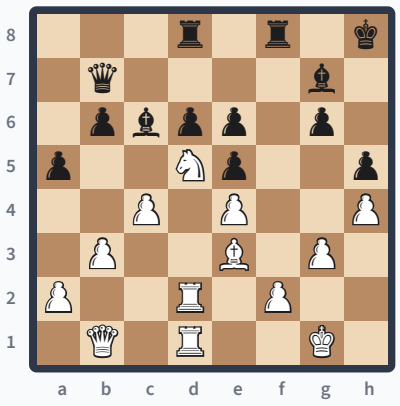
3 Find the best move for White!



Reti v Romanovsky
Moscow 1925

Answer:

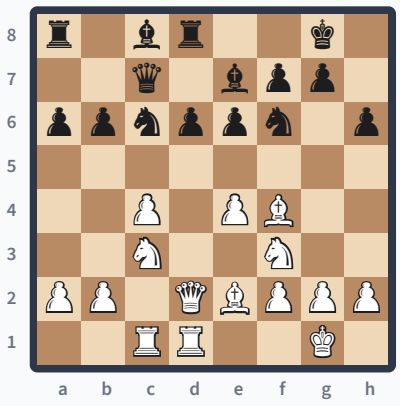
4 Find the best move for White!



Petrosian v Ljubojevic
Manila 1974

Answer:

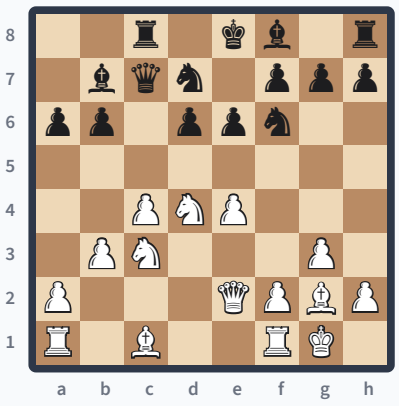
5 Find the best move for White!



Grischuk v Kanep
EU-ch U12 1995

Answer:

6 Find the best move for White!



Kasparov v Salov
World Cup 1989

Answer:

Tip: first find the plan for this structure, then check the tactics that serve it.

Score: ____ / 6

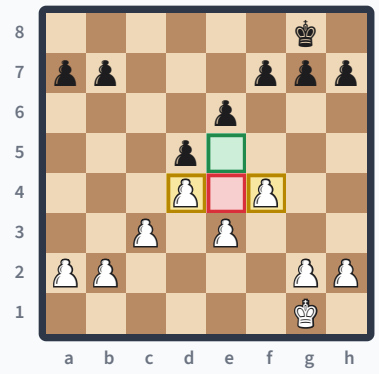
THE STONEWALL

A wall of pawns on d4, e3 and f4

Lesson 6 · Strategy
Level 4 Strategy

1. The Wall

D4 E3 F4

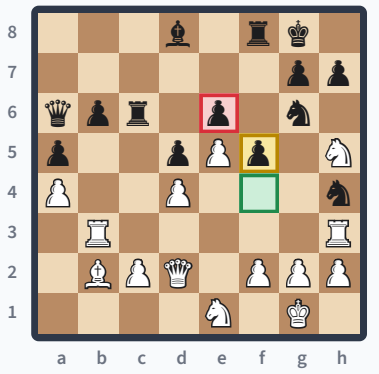


`c3-d4-e3-f4: a light-square chain`

- The pawns make a rock-solid centre, and the Knight jumps to **e5**, where no pawn can chase it.
- The price: a hole on **e4**, and a bad dark-squared Bishop for the Stonewall side.

2. Chigorin–Tarrasch

STONEWALL

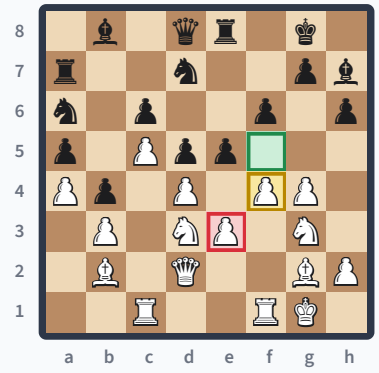


`38...f4 39.g3 Nf5`

- Black has the Stonewall: Knight to e5, then attack on the kingside.
- **38...f4!** 39.g3 Nf5: Black keeps an edge (engine +0.5).
- Chigorin v Tarrasch, St Petersburg m 1893

3. Grischuk–Morozevich

STONEWALL

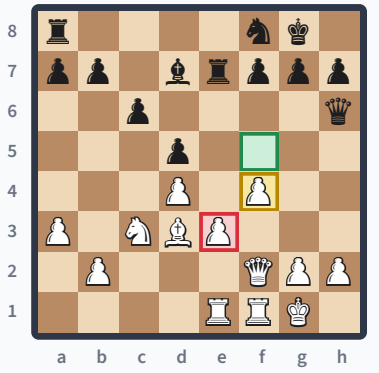


`22.f5 Kh8 23.e4`

- White has the Stonewall: Knight to e5, then attack on the kingside.
- **22.f5!** 22...Kh8 23.e4: White is clearly better (engine +1.3).
- Grischuk v Morozevich, TCh-RUS 2004

4. Petrosian–Beliavsky

STONEWALL



`18.f5 g6 19.Qg3`

- White has the Stonewall: Knight to e5, then attack on the kingside.
- **18.f5!** 18...g6 19.Qg3: White is clearly better (engine +1.5).
- Petrosian v Beliavsky, URS-ch50 1983

Stonewall Plans

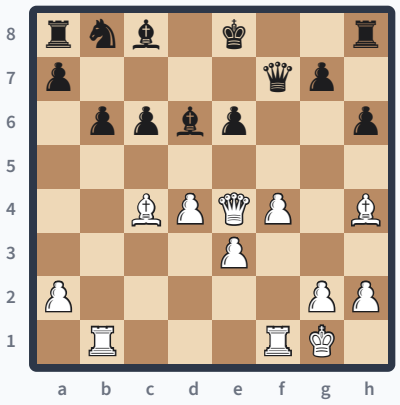
1. **Stonewall side:** Ne5, Rf3-h3 or g4-g5 for a kingside attack; trade the bad Bishop if you can.
2. **Opponent:** trade the e5-Knight, occupy **e4**, and play on the dark squares and the queenside.
3. The Bird's Opening (Lesson 10) and the Dutch use the same idea.

PUZZLES: THE STONEWALL

Six positions from master games

Lesson 6 · Strategy Puzzles
Level 4 Strategy

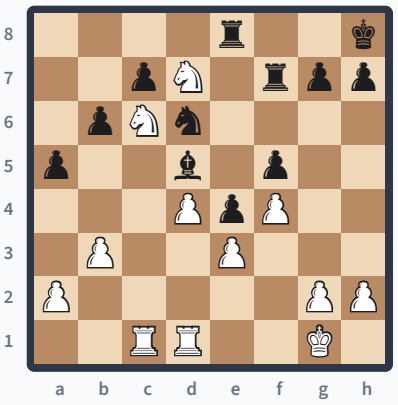
1 **Find the best move for White!**



Carlsen v Groenn
ch-NOR 2005

Answer:

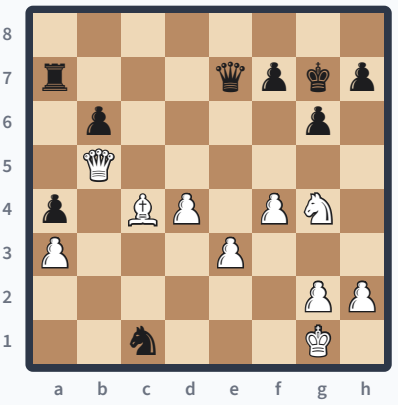
2 **Find the best move for White!**



Pillsbury v Fox
Cambridge Springs 1904

Answer:

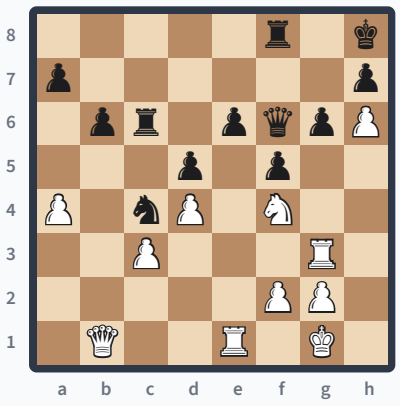
3 **Find the best move for White!**



Caruana v Anand
82nd Tata Steel GpA 2020

Answer:

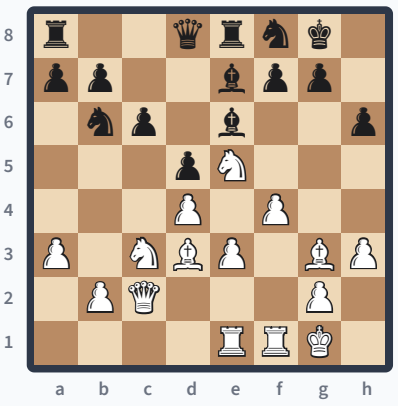
4 **Find the best move for Black!**



Reshevsky v Botvinnik
World Championship 18th 1948

Answer:

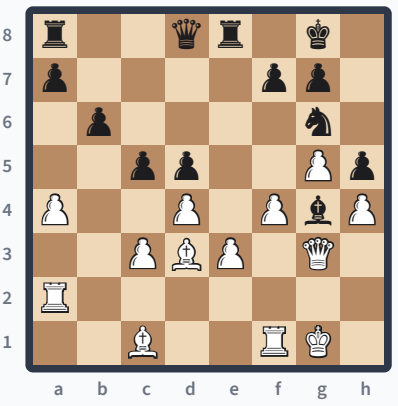
5 **Find the best move for White!**



Short v Andersson
Keres mem 1998

Answer:

6 **Find the best move for White!**



Geller v Sliwa
Gothenburg Interzonal 1955

Answer:

Tip: first find the plan for this structure, then check the tactics that serve it.

Score: ____ / 6

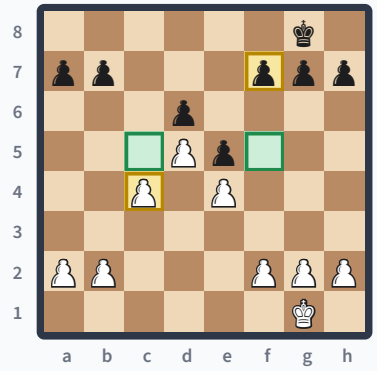
LOCKED CENTRE: PAWN STORMS

King's Indian structure: a race on opposite wings

Lesson 7 · Strategy
Level 4 Strategy

1. Where the Chain Points

D5 + E4 VS D6 + E5

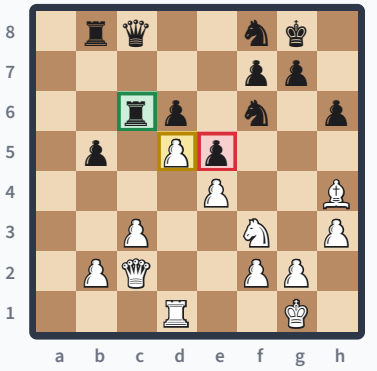


```
Each side attacks where its pawns point
```

- White's chain points to the **queenside**: c4-c5 breaks. Black's chain points to the **kingside**: ...f5-f4 and ...g5-g4.
- With the centre locked, speed matters more than material. A tempo lost is often the game.

2. Carlsen–Mamedyarov

LOCKED CENTRE

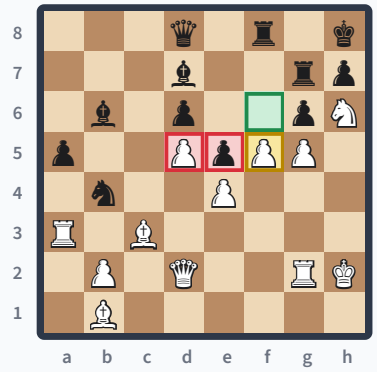


```
26.dxc6 Ne8 27.Be7
```

- White has more space: play on the side where your pawn chain points.
- **26.dxc6!** 26...Ne8 27.Be7: White keeps an edge (engine +0.4).
- Carlsen v Mamedyarov, 51st Biel GM 2018

3. Bogoljubow–Rubinstein

LOCKED CENTRE

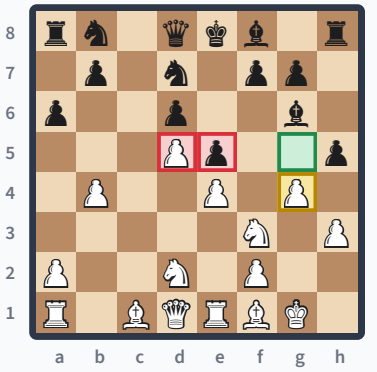


```
44.f6 Bb5 45.fxg7+
```

- White has more space: play on the side where your pawn chain points.
- **44.f6!** 44...Bb5 45.fxg7+, winning 4 points.
- Bogoljubow v Rubinstein, Maehrisch Ostrau 1923

4. Anand–Topalov: 16.g5!

LOCKED CENTRE



```
16.g5 Be7 17.Nc4
```

- White has more space: play on the side where your pawn chain points.
- **16.g5!** 16...Be7 17.Nc4: White is clearly better (engine +2.6).
- Anand v Topalov, Sparkassen Cat XXI 2001

Racing on Opposite Wings

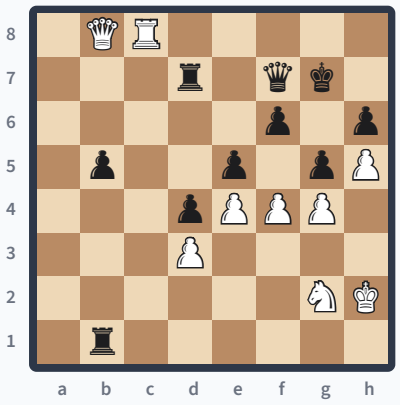
1. Play on the side where your pawn chain points; attack the base of the enemy chain.
2. Don't defend passively: count tempi. Opening a file near the enemy King first usually decides.
3. Close the wing where you are attacked (e.g. g4 or ...c5) only if it costs the opponent more time than you.

PUZZLES: LOCKED CENTRE

Six positions from master games

Lesson 7 · Strategy Puzzles
Level 4 Strategy

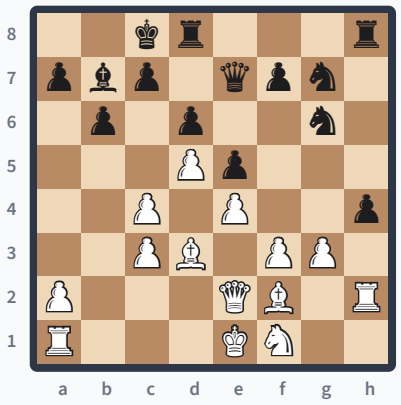
1 Find the best move for Black!



Tartakower v Nimzowitsch
Dresden 1926

Answer:

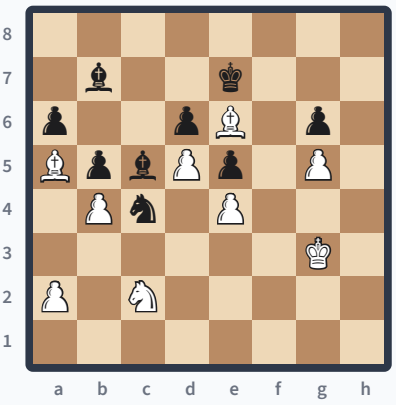
2 Find the best move for White!



Botvinnik v Keres
URS-ch12 1940

Answer:

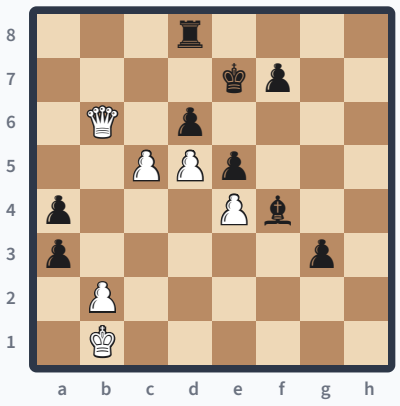
3 Find the best move for White!



Smyslov v Euwe
World Championship 18th 1948

Answer:

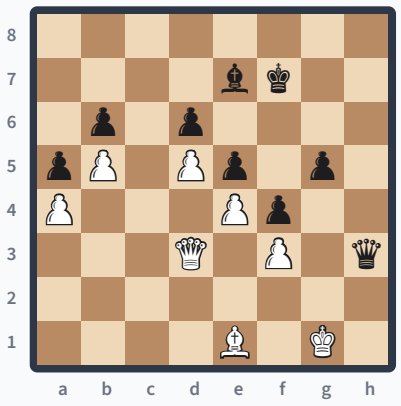
4 Find the best move for Black!



Shirov v Kasparov
Tilburg Fontys 1997

Answer:

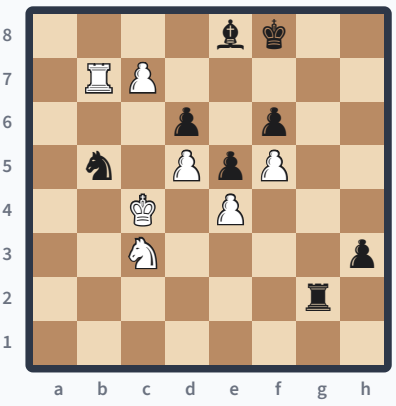
5 Find the best move for Black!



Keres v Larsen
Hoogovens 1964

Answer:

6 Find the best move for White!



Karpov v Salov
World Cup 1991

Answer:

Tip: first find the plan for this structure, then check the tactics that serve it.

Score: ____ / 6

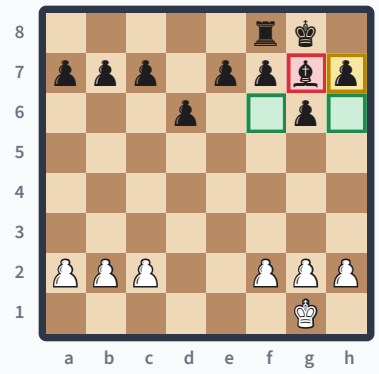
THE FIANCHETTO

Strengths, holes and how to attack it

Lesson 8 · Strategy
Level 4 Strategy

1. The Fianchettoed Bishop

G6 + BG7

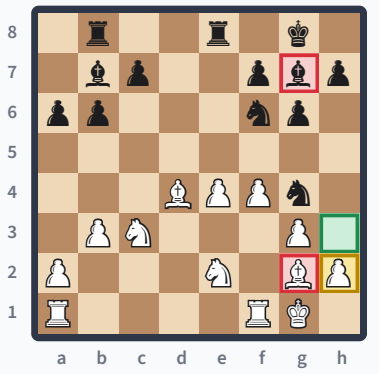


`Long diagonal power · holes on f6 and h6`

- The **g7-Bishop** rakes the long diagonal and guards the King. The pawn on g6 leaves holes on **f6** and **h6**.
- The standard attack: **Qd2 + Bh6** to trade the Bishop, then **h4-h5** to open the h-file.

2. Botvinnik–Smyslov

FIANCHETTO

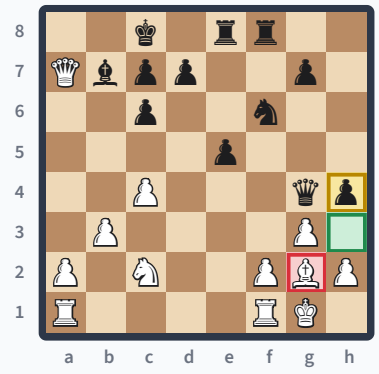


`18.h3 c5 19.Bxf6`

- White attacks a fianchettoed King: trade the Bishop, open the h-file, use the holes.
- **18.h3!** 18...c5 19.Bxf6: White is clearly better (engine +1.1).
- Botvinnik v Smyslov, World Championship 20th 1954

3. Kasparov–Karpov

FIANCHETTO

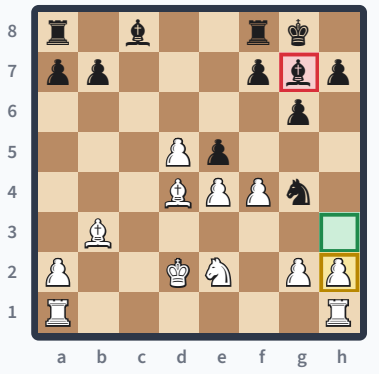


`20...h3 21.Bh1 Ne4`

- Black attacks a fianchettoed King: trade the Bishop, open the h-file, use the holes.
- **20...h3!** 21.Bh1 Ne4: Black keeps an edge (engine +0.8).
- Kasparov v Karpov, World Championship 35th-KK5 1990

4. Kramnik–Svidler: 19.h3!

FIANCHETTO



`19.h3 exd4 20.hxg4`

- White attacks a fianchettoed King: trade the Bishop, open the h-file, use the holes.
- **19.h3!** 19...exd4 20.hxg4: White is clearly better (engine +2.1).
- Kramnik v Svidler, Dortmund 1998

Attacking and Defending the Fianchetto

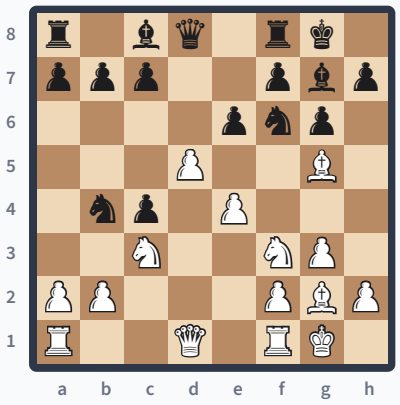
1. **Attack:** trade the fianchetto Bishop (Bh6), open the h-file with h4-h5, and land on the dark holes.
2. **Defence:** keep the Bishop, don't weaken further (avoid ...h6), and counterattack in the centre.
3. Without its Bishop, a fianchettoed King is full of holes.

PUZZLES: THE FIANCHETTO

Six positions from master games

Lesson 8 · Strategy Puzzles
Level 4 Strategy

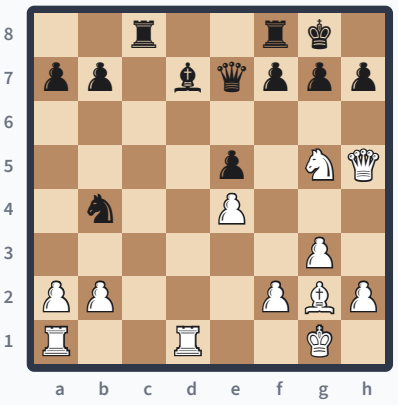
1 Find the best move for Black!



Ivanchuk v Polgar
Linares 14th 1997

Answer:

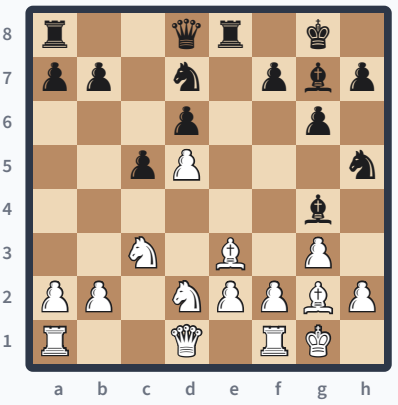
2 Find the best move for Black!



Firouzja v Caruana
FIDE Candidates 2022

Answer:

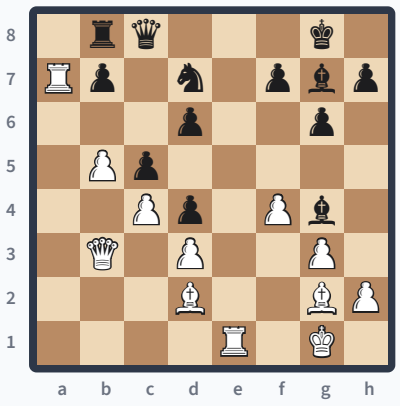
3 Find the best move for White!



Eljanov v Topalov
Corus A 2008

Answer:

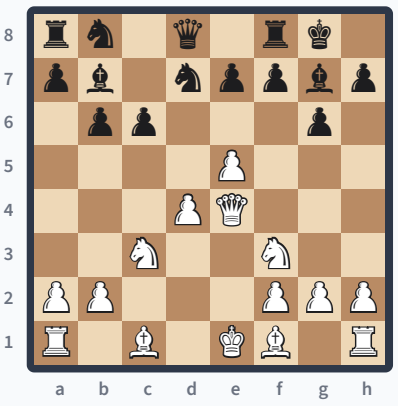
4 Find the best move for White!



Andersson v Romero Holmes
Rome 1986

Answer:

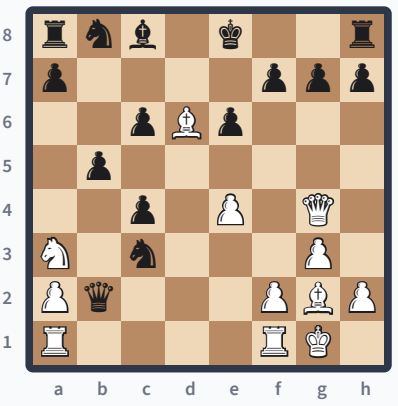
5 Find the best move for White!



Bronstein v Bogatyrev
Moscow-ch 1947

Answer:

6 Find the best move for Black!



Giri v Grandelius
18th Sigeman & Co 2010

Answer:

Tip: first find the plan for this structure, then check the tactics that serve it.

Score: ____ / 6

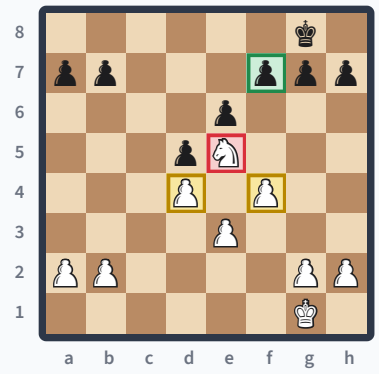
THE PILLSBURY KNIGHT

A Knight on e5, backed by pawns on d4 and f4

Lesson 9 · Strategy
Level 4 Strategy

1. The Pillsbury Set-Up

NE5 + D4 + F4

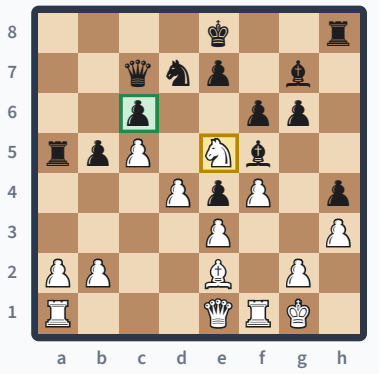


```
Pillsbury's attacking pattern from the QGD
```

- The Knight on **e5**, supported by **d4 and f4**, eyes f7, d7, c6 and g6. It is very hard to remove.
- Next comes **Rf3-h3** or **Qf3/Qh5**, swinging pieces towards the King.

2. Caruana–Giri: 18.Nxc6!

KNIGHT ON E5

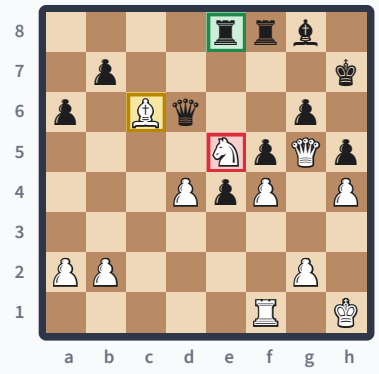


```
18.Nxc6 Ra8 19.Bxb5
```

- White has a Knight on e5 backed by d4 and f4: the Pillsbury set-up.
- **18.Nxc6!** 18...Ra8 19.Bxb5, winning 2 points.
- Caruana v Giri, 74th Tata Steel GMA 2012

3. Short–Gelfand: 30.Bxe8!

KNIGHT ON E5

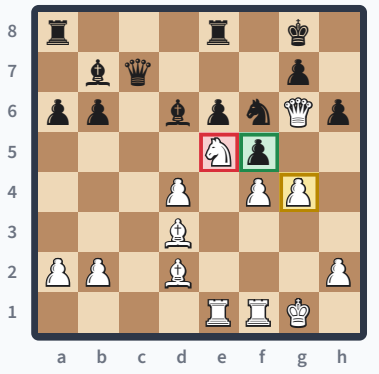


```
30.Bxe8 Rxe8 31.Rc1
```

- White has a Knight on e5 backed by d4 and f4: the Pillsbury set-up.
- **30.Bxe8!** 30...Rxe8 31.Rc1: White is clearly better (engine +1.1).
- Short v Gelfand, Linares 1992

4. Kamsky–Anand: 27.gxf5!

KNIGHT ON E5



```
27.gxf5 Bxe5 28.fxe5
```

- White has a Knight on e5 backed by d4 and f4: the Pillsbury set-up.
- **27.gxf5!** 27...Bxe5 28.fxe5, winning 1 point.
- Kamsky v Anand, Dos Hermanas 1996

Using the Pillsbury Knight

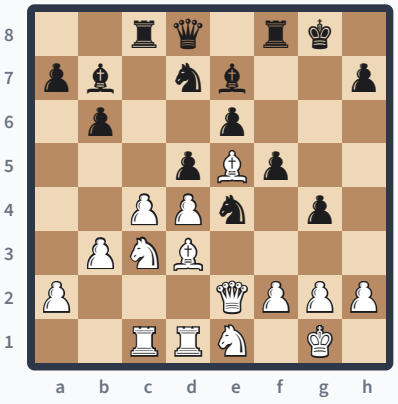
1. Support the Knight with pawns, not pieces: **d4 + f4** makes it permanent.
2. Bring the heavy pieces to the kingside (Rf3-h3, Qe1-h4); the Knight joins with Nxf7 or Ng4.
3. The defender's plan: trade it (...Nd7 or ...Bd6xe5) or undermine it with ...f6.

PUZZLES: THE PILLSBURY KNIGHT

Six positions from master games

Lesson 9 · Strategy Puzzles
Level 4 Strategy

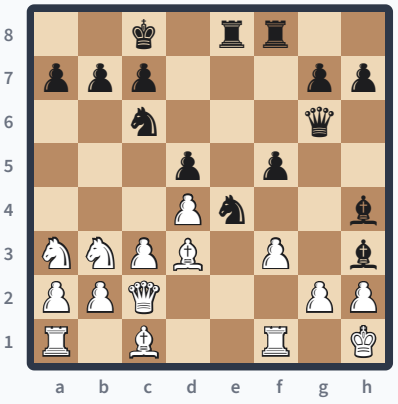
1 Find the best move for Black!



Bogoljubow v Botvinnik
Nottingham 1936

Answer:

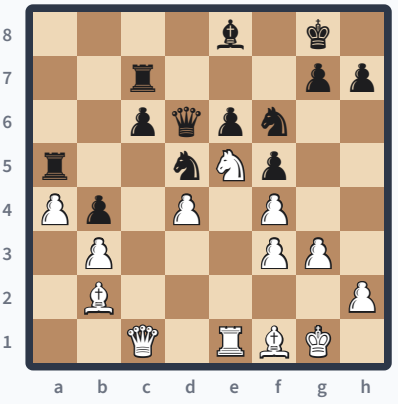
2 Find the best move for Black!



Ivanchuk v Anand
Reggio Emilia8889 1988

Answer:

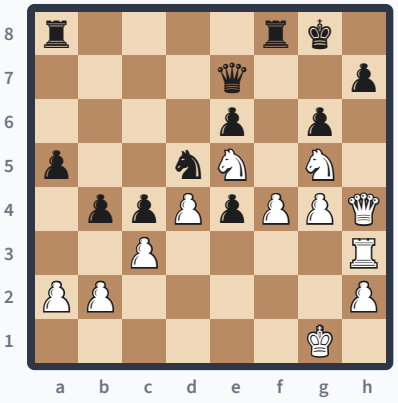
3 Find the best move for White!



Gelfand v Lombaers
Gibraltar Masters 2017

Answer:

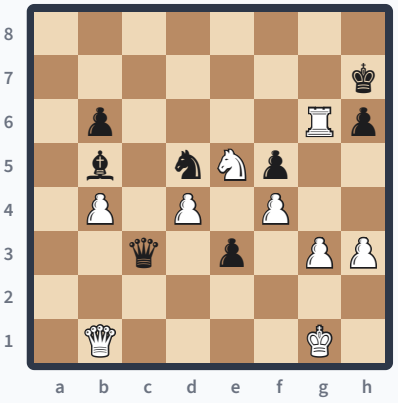
4 Find the best move for White!



Yanofsky v Portisch
Munich olm fin-B 1958

Answer:

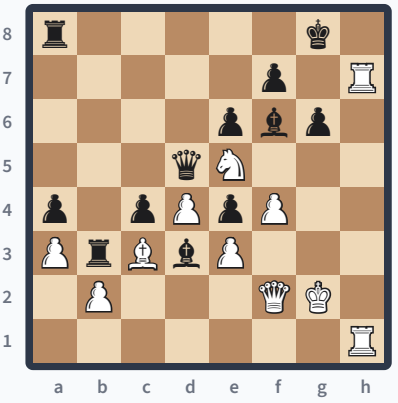
5 Find the best move for White!



Lasker v Tinsley
London 1899

Answer:

6 Find the best move for White!



Zukertort v Steinitz
World Championship 1st 1886

Answer:

Tip: first find the plan for this structure, then check the tactics that serve it.

Score: ____ / 6

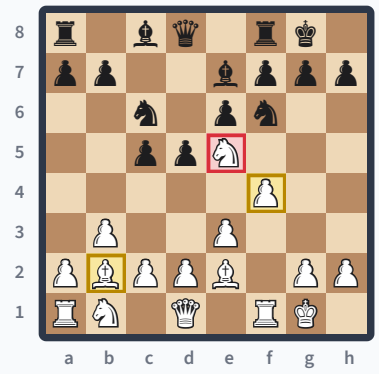
BIRD'S OPENING

1.f4: the Pillsbury Knight with a fianchetto behind it

Lesson 10 · Openings
Level 4 Openings

1. The Set-Up

NE5 + F4 + BB2

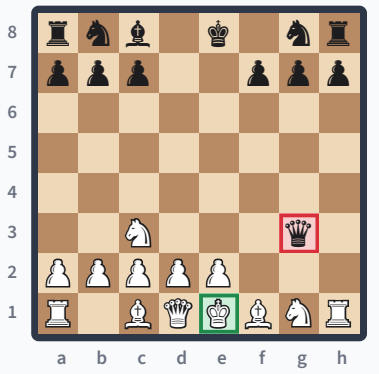


```
1.f4 d5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.e3 e6 4.b3 Be7
5.Bb2 O-O 6.Be2 c5 7.O-O Nc6 8.Ne5
```

- The Knight lands on **e5**, backed by the f4-pawn and the b2-Bishop: a Pillsbury Knight with a fianchetto behind it.
- Next: Qe1-h4 or Rf3-h3 towards the black King.

2. From's Gambit Trap

1...E5!?

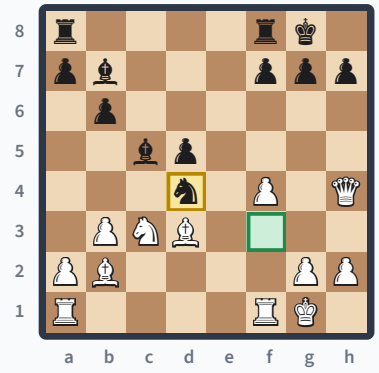


```
1.f4 e5 2.fxe5 d6 3.exd6 Bxd6 4.Nc3??
Qh4+ 5.g3 Bxg3+ 6.hxg3 Qxg3#
```

- After 1.f4 the e1-h4 diagonal is weak. **4.Nc3??** walks into ...Qh4+ and mate on g3.
- The safe move is **4.Nf3**, covering h4.

3. Penkov–Giri: 17...Nf3+!

1.F4

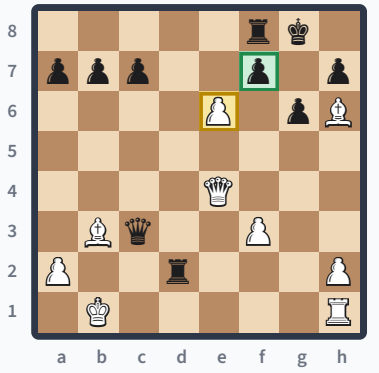


```
17...Nf3+ 18.Kh1 Nxh4
```

- Black punishes a slip in the Bird.
- **17...Nf3+!** 18.Kh1 Nxh4, winning 9 points.
- Penkov v Giri, Chigorin CC 2005

4. Larsen–Perez Perez

1.F4



```
23.exf7+ Kh8 24.Bxd2
```

- White plays the Bird and cashes in.
- **23.exf7+!** 23...Kh8 24.Bxd2, winning 6 points.
- Larsen v Perez Perez, Dortmund 1961

Bird's Opening: Key Ideas

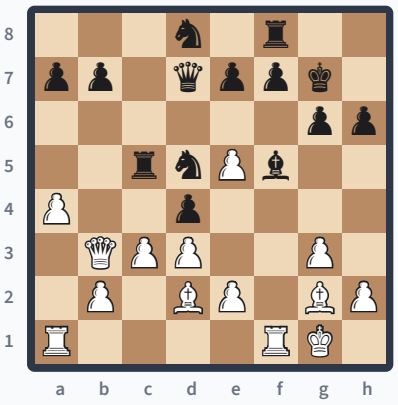
1. Set up with **f4, Nf3, e3, b3, Bb2**: the b2-Bishop and the f4-pawn both support **Ne5** (Lessons 8 and 9).
2. Then Be2 or Bb5, castle, and attack with Qe1-h4 or Rf3-h3.
3. Watch out for From's Gambit (1...e5!?): never weaken the e1-h4 diagonal.

PUZZLES: BIRD'S OPENING

Six positions from master games

Lesson 10 · Openings Puzzles
Level 4 Openings

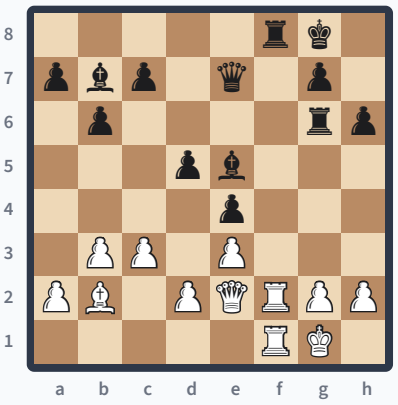
1 Find the best move for White!



Larsen v Dunkelblum
Hoogovens 1964

Answer:

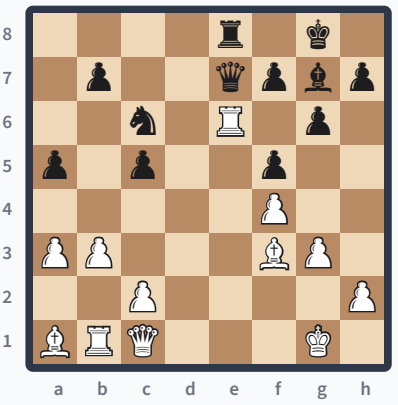
2 Find the best move for White!



Bird v Taubenhaus
DSB-04.Kongress 1885

Answer:

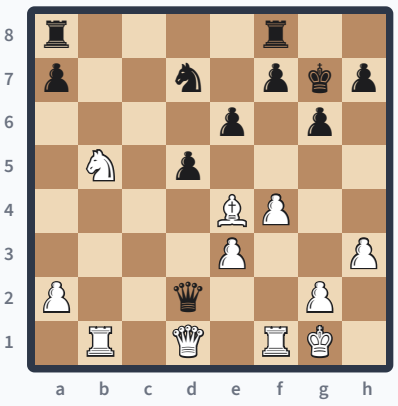
3 Find the best move for Black!



Birk v Larsen
Hedehusene op 1991

Answer:

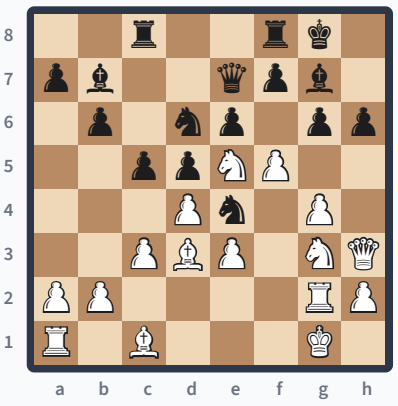
4 Find the best move for Black!



Larsen v Udovcic
Sarajevo 1960

Answer:

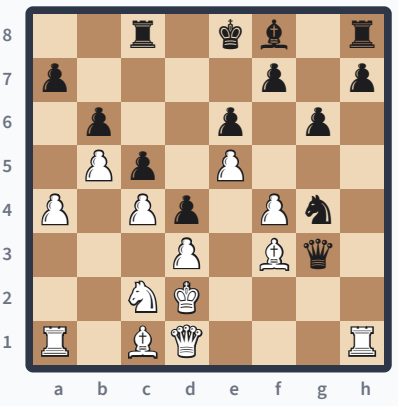
5 Find the best move for Black!



Larsen v Bobotsov
Hoogovens 1964

Answer:

6 Find the best move for Black!



Bird v Gunsberg
USA-06.Congress 1889

Answer:

Tip: ask what the opening is about (a square, a file, a diagonal), then look for the move that serves it.

Score: ____ / 6

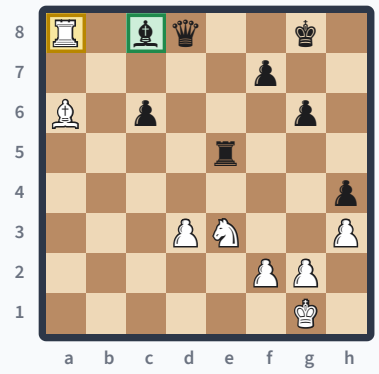
THE EXCHANGE SACRIFICE

A Rook for a minor piece, for something more important

Lesson 11 · Strategy
Level 4 Strategy

1. Tartakower–Rubinstein

EXCHANGE SAC

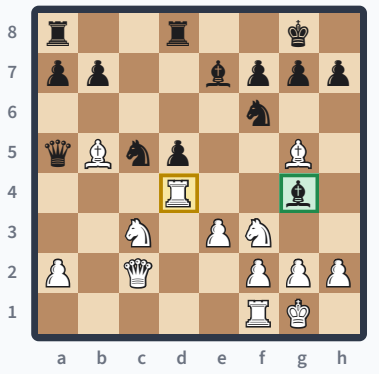


`27.Rxc8 Qxc8 28.Bxc8`

- White gives a Rook for the Bishop on **c8**. Quiet d4 gives a worse game (-4.2).
- **27.Rxc8!** 27...Qxc8 28.Bxc8, winning 7 points.
- Tartakower v Rubinstein, The Hague 1921

2. Reti–Maroczy: 16.Rxg4!

EXCHANGE SAC

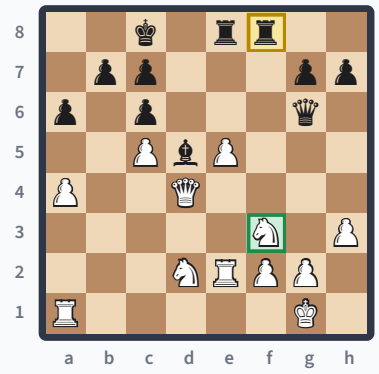


`16.Rxg4 Rac8 17.Qd2`

- White gives a Rook for the Bishop on **g4**. Quiet Bxf6 gives a worse game (-0.5).
- **16.Rxg4!** 16...Rac8 17.Qd2, winning 3 points.
- If taken: 16...Nxg4 17.Bxe7 Rdc8 (+3.5 for White).
- Reti v Maroczy, Berlin 1920

3. Smyslov–Geller

EXCHANGE SAC

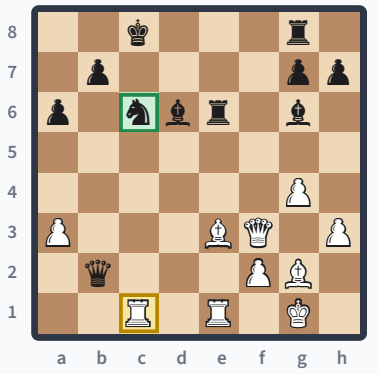


`26...Rxf3 27.Qg4+ Qxg4`

- Black gives a Rook for the Knight on **f3**. Quiet Bxf3 gives a worse game (-3.1).
- **26...Rxf3!** 27.Qg4+ Qxg4: Black is clearly better (engine +1.1).
- If taken: 27.Nxf3 Bxf3 28.g3 (+4.5 for Black).
- Smyslov v Geller, URS-ch41 1973

4. Giri–Mamedyarov

EXCHANGE SAC



`24.Rxc6+ Kd7 25.Rxa6`

- White gives a Rook for the Knight on **c6**. Quiet Re2 gives a worse game (-2.2).
- **24.Rxc6+!** 24...Kd7 25.Rxa6, winning 4 points.
- If taken: 24...bxc6 25.Qxc6+ Kb8 (+5.3 for White).
- Giri v Mamedyarov, Croatia GCT 2019

When to Give the Exchange

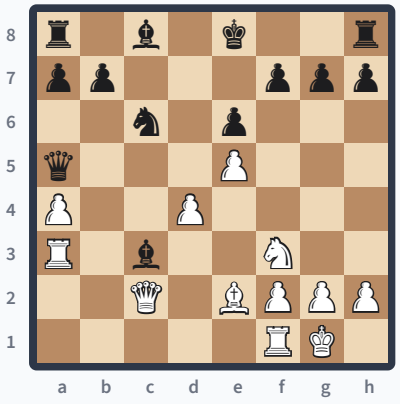
1. **Typical reasons:** destroy the King's pawn shield, remove a key defender, win a strong square, or break up the pawns (...Rxc3 in the Sicilian).
2. A Knight on a strong outpost or a Bishop that controls a colour can be worth more than a passive Rook.
3. Petrosian gave the exchange for **long-term** control. Count squares and weaknesses, not just points.

PUZZLES: THE EXCHANGE SACRIFICE

Six positions from master games

Lesson 11 · Strategy Puzzles
Level 4 Strategy

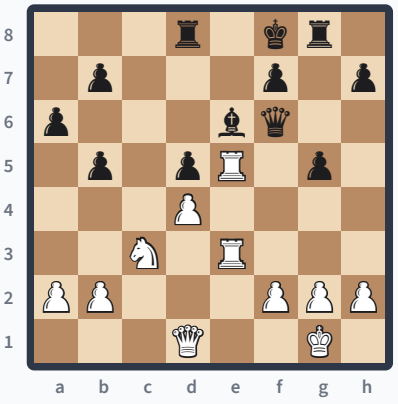
1 **White to move. Is it time for an exchange sacrifice?**



Alekhine v Euwe
World Championship 16th 1935

Answer:

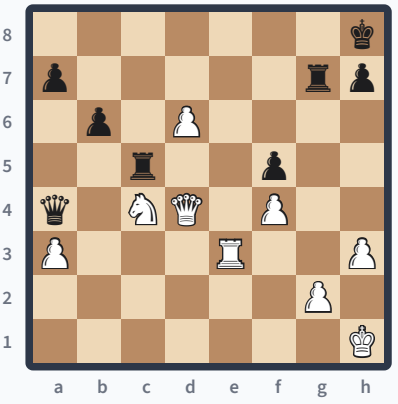
2 **White to move. Is it time for an exchange sacrifice?**



Morphy v Anderssen
Paris m1 1858

Answer:

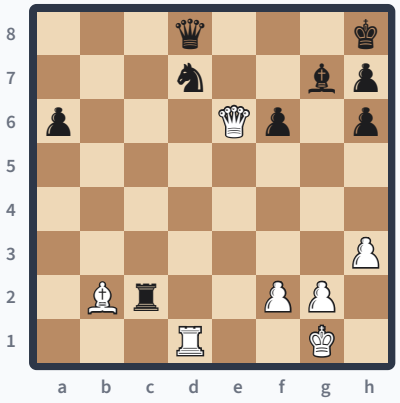
3 **Black to move. Is it time for an exchange sacrifice?**



Anderssen v Morphy
Paris m1 1858

Answer:

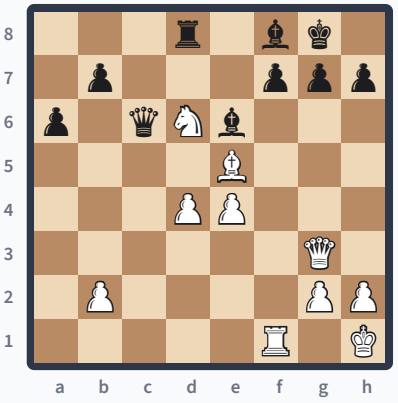
4 **White to move. Is it time for an exchange sacrifice?**



Anand v Carlsen
2nd London Chess Classic 2010

Answer:

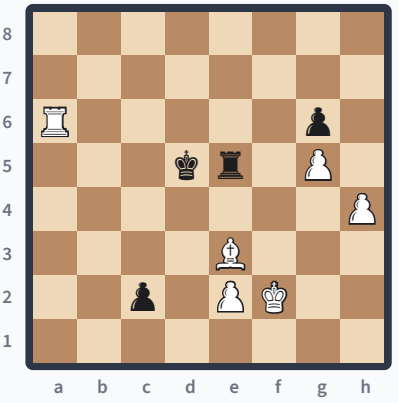
5 **Black to move. Is it time for an exchange sacrifice?**



Geller v Andersson
Moscow 1981

Answer:

6 **Black to move. Is it time for an exchange sacrifice?**



Botvinnik v Geller
URS-ch19 1951

Answer:

Tip: first find the plan for this structure, then check the tactics that serve it.

Score: ____ / 6

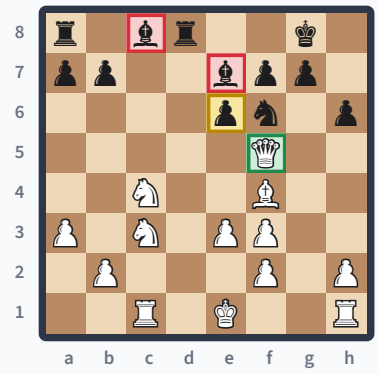
THE BISHOP PAIR

Two Bishops need open lines

Lesson 12 · Strategy
Level 4 Strategy

1. Ivanchuk–Giri

TWO BISHOPS

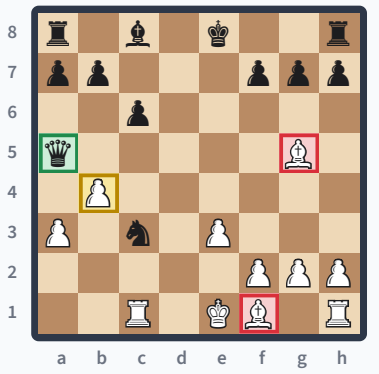


`16...exf5 17.Bc7 Rd7`

- Black has the two Bishops: open the position for them.
- **16...exf5!** 17.Bc7 Rd7: Black keeps an edge (engine +0.4).
- Ivanchuk v Giri, 74th Tata Steel GMA 2012

2. Kasparov–Smyslov

TWO BISHOPS

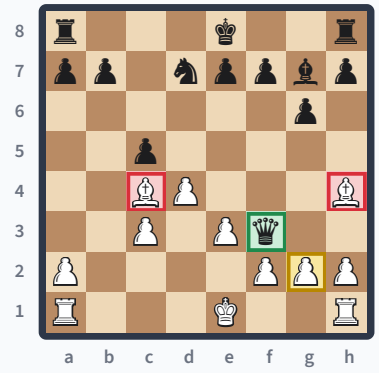


`15.bxa5 Ne4`

- White has the two Bishops: open the position for them.
- **15.bxa5!** 15...Ne4: White keeps an edge (engine +0.8).
- Kasparov v Smyslov, Candidats final 1984

3. Aronian–Svidler

TWO BISHOPS

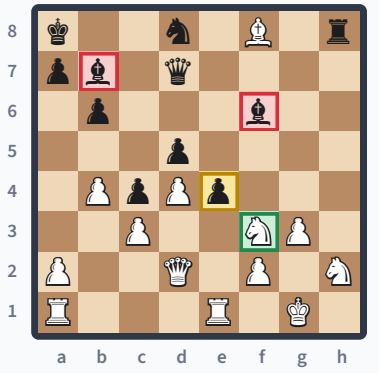


`15.gxf3 cxd4 16.cxd4`

- White has the two Bishops: open the position for them.
- **15.gxf3!** 15...cxd4 16.cxd4: White keeps an edge (engine +0.5).
- Aronian v Svidler, 17th TCh-Eur 2009

4. Shirov–Rozentalis

TWO BISHOPS



`27...exf3 28.g4 Rxh2`

- Black has the two Bishops: open the position for them.
- **27...exf3!** 28.g4 Rxh2, winning 6 points.
- Shirov v Rozentalis, URS-FL56 1988

Making the Bishops Count

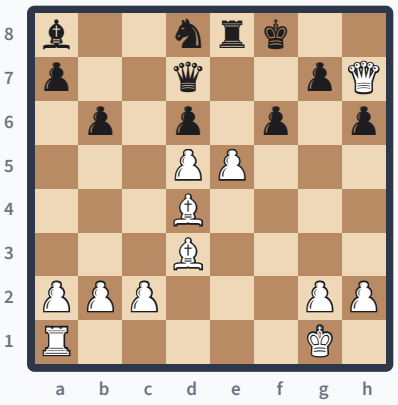
1. **With the pair:** open lines with pawn breaks, avoid trading one Bishop cheaply, and use both colours at once.
2. **Against it:** keep pawns fixed, win outposts for your Knights, and trade one Bishop when you can.
3. In open endgames the Bishop pair is often worth about half a pawn extra.

PUZZLES: THE BISHOP PAIR

Six positions from master games

Lesson 12 · Strategy Puzzles
Level 4 Strategy

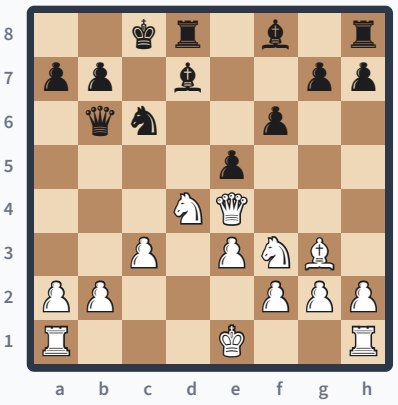
1 Find the best move for White!



Capablanca v Liebenstein
New York National 1913

Answer:

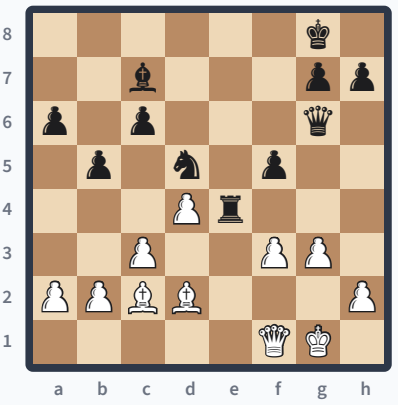
2 Find the best move for Black!



Marshall v Capablanca
New York 1927

Answer:

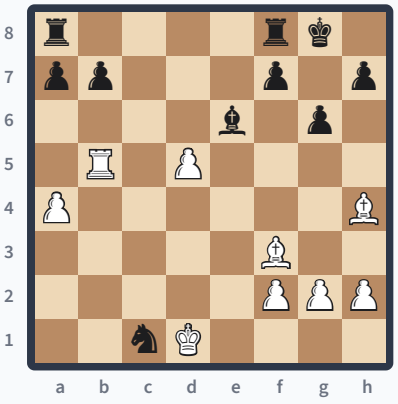
3 Find the best move for White!



Svidler v Leko
WCh 2007

Answer:

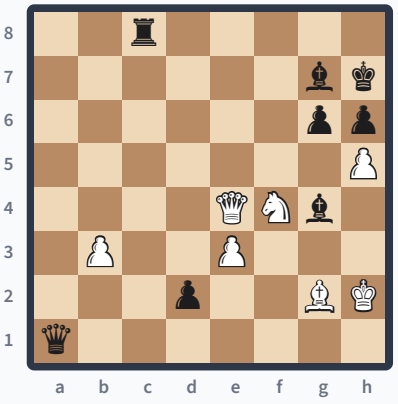
4 Find the best move for White!



Radjabov v Shirov
III Kings' Tournament 2009

Answer:

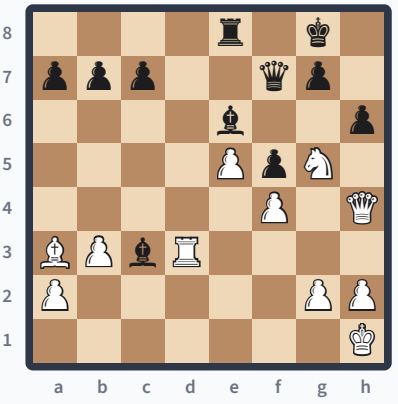
5 Find the best move for Black!



Bernstein v Euwe
Zuerich 1934

Answer:

6 Find the best move for Black!



Zukertort v Anderssen
Berlin m 1868

Answer:

Tip: first find the plan for this structure, then check the tactics that serve it.

Score: ____ / 6

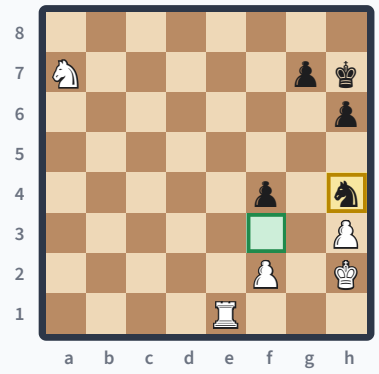
BLOCKADE AND OVERPROTECTION

Nimzowitsch's ideas: stop the pawn, protect the key square twice

Lesson 13 · Strategy
Level 4 Strategy

1. Anderssen–Steinitz

BLOCKADE

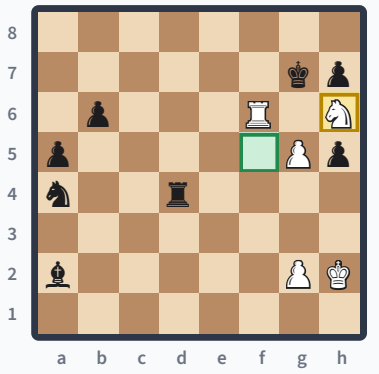


`44...Nf3+ 45.Kg2 Nxe1+`

- Black blockades an enemy pawn with a Knight.
- **44...Nf3+!** 45.Kg2 Nxe1+: Black keeps an edge (engine +0.9).
- Anderssen v Steinitz, London m1 1866

2. Polgar–Topalov: 41.Nf5+!

BLOCKADE

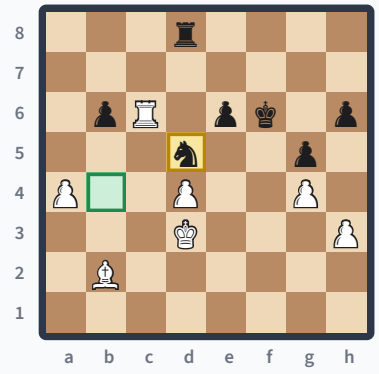


`41.Nf5+ Kg8 42.Nxd4`

- White blockades an enemy pawn with a Knight.
- **41.Nf5+!** 41...Kg8 42.Nxd4, winning 5 points.
- Polgar v Topalov, Linares 1994

3. Shirov–Beliavsky

BLOCKADE

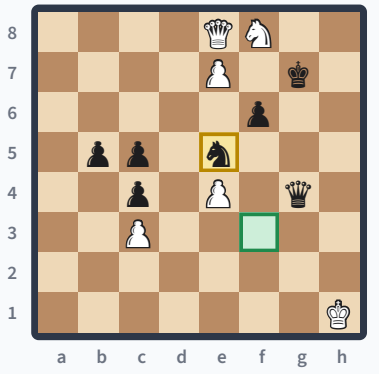


`37...Nb4+ 38.Ke4 Nxc6`

- Black blockades an enemy pawn with a Knight.
- **37...Nb4+!** 38.Ke4 Nxc6, winning 5 points.
- Shirov v Beliavsky, Biel 1992

4. Grischuk–Kamsky

BLOCKADE



`69...Nf3 70.Ne6+ Qxe6`

- Black blockades an enemy pawn with a Knight.
- **69...Nf3!** 70.Ne6+ Qxe6, winning 3 points.
- Grischuk v Kamsky, 4th FIDE GP 2009

Nimzowitsch's Rules

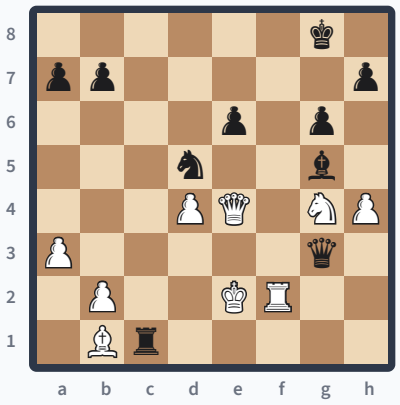
1. **Blockade:** stop a passed or isolated pawn with a piece directly in front of it. The Knight is the ideal blockader.
2. A blockaded pawn becomes a target, and the blockading piece cannot easily be attacked.
3. **Overprotection:** guard your key point (like e5) more times than needed; then every piece stays active.

PUZZLES: BLOCKADE

Six positions from master games

Lesson 13 · Strategy Puzzles
Level 4 Strategy

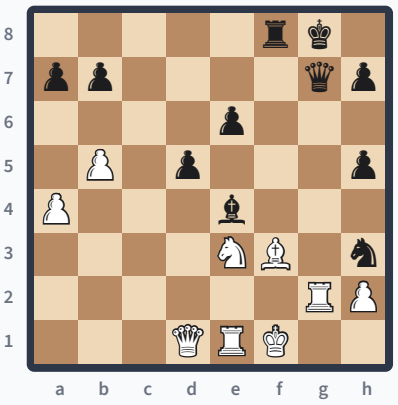
1 Find the best move for Black!



Nimzowitsch v Bernstein
Ostende-B 1907

Answer:

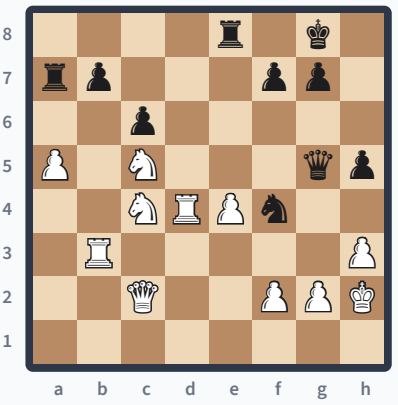
2 Find the best move for Black!



Nakamura v Antal
FSGMA April 2002

Answer:

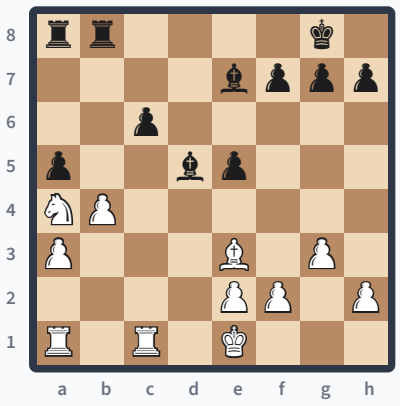
3 Find the best move for White!



Portisch v Larsen
Candidats qf3 1977

Answer:

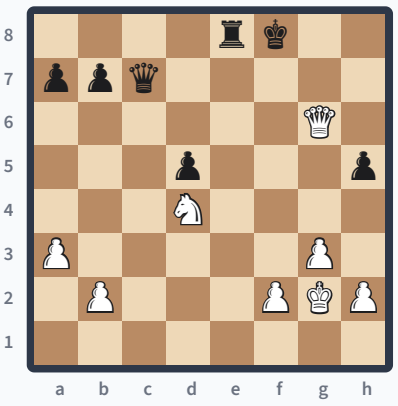
4 Find the best move for White!



Andersson v Timman
Niksic 1983

Answer:

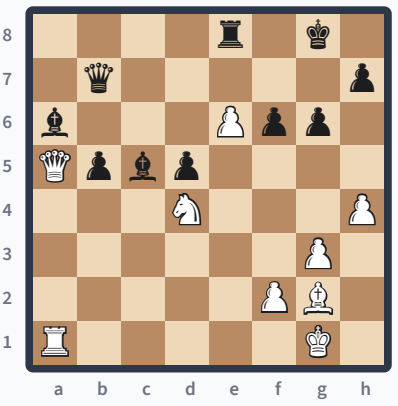
5 Find the best move for White!



Shirov v Rozentalis
Bundesliga 9900 1999

Answer:

6 Find the best move for White!



Svidler v Harikrishna
7th Gibtelecom Masters 2009

Answer:

Tip: first find the plan for this structure, then check the tactics that serve it.

Score: ____ / 6

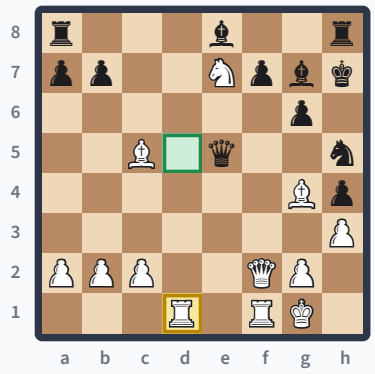
IMPROVE YOUR WORST PIECE

Karpov's quiet strength: find the piece doing nothing

Lesson 14 · Strategy
Level 4 Strategy

1. Tarrasch–Bird: 23.Rd5!

QUIET MOVE

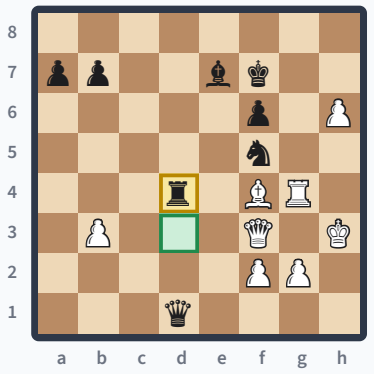


```
23.Rd5 Qxd5 24.Nxd5
```

- No tactics: White improves a piece.
- **23.Rd5!** 23...Qxd5 24.Nxd5, winning 4 points.
- Tarrasch v Bird, Hastings 1895

2. Tal–Keres: 43...Rd3!

QUIET MOVE

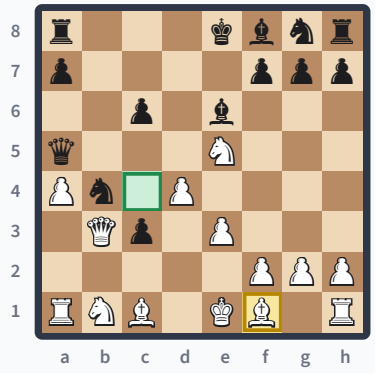


```
43...Rd3 44.Kh2 Rxf3
```

- No tactics: Black improves a piece.
- **43...Rd3!** 44.Kh2 Rxf3, winning 4 points.
- Tal v Keres, URS-chT 1959

3. Carlsen–Nakamura

QUIET MOVE

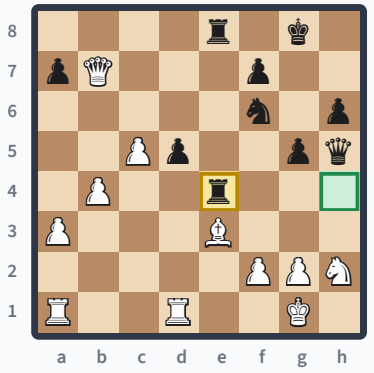


```
14.Bc4 Bxc4 15.Nxc4
```

- No tactics: White improves a piece.
- **14.Bc4!** 14...Bxc4 15.Nxc4: White is clearly better (engine +2.4).
- Carlsen v Nakamura, 2nd Sinquefield Cup 2014

4. Steinitz–Lasker

QUIET MOVE



```
24...Rh4 25.Qc7 Ng4
```

- No tactics: Black improves a piece.
- **24...Rh4!** 25.Qc7 Ng4: Black is clearly better (engine +3.0).
- Steinitz v Lasker, Nuremberg 1896

The Worst-Piece Question

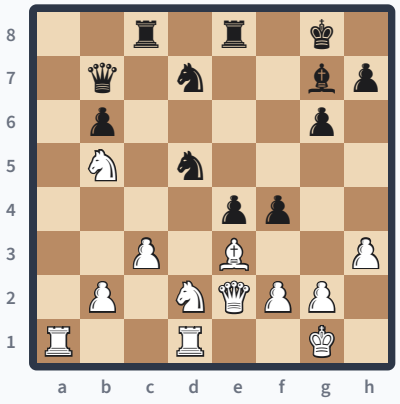
1. When there is nothing to calculate, ask: **which of my pieces is worst?** Then find it a better square.
2. Typical improvements: a Knight to an outpost, a Rook to an open file, a Bishop to a better diagonal.
3. Small improvements add up; the opponent often cracks before you need any tactics.

PUZZLES: IMPROVE YOUR WORST PIECE

Six positions from master games

Lesson 14 · Strategy Puzzles
Level 4 Strategy

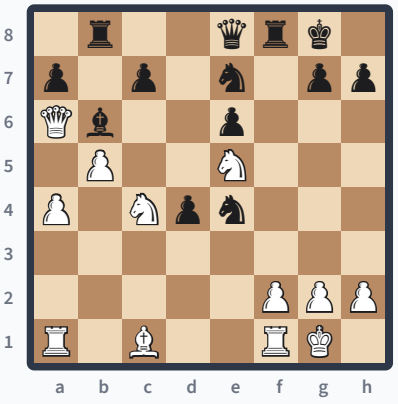
1 **Find the best quiet move for White!**



Reti v Alekhine
New York 1924

Answer:

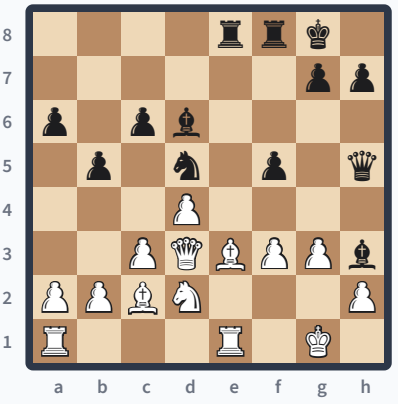
2 **Find the best quiet move for White!**



Karpov v Anand
Dortmund 1997

Answer:

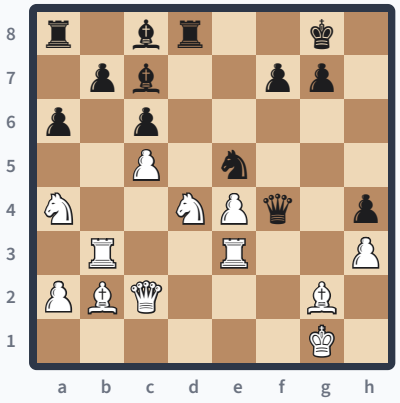
3 **Find the best quiet move for White!**



Shirov v Aronian
Shanghai Masters 2010

Answer:

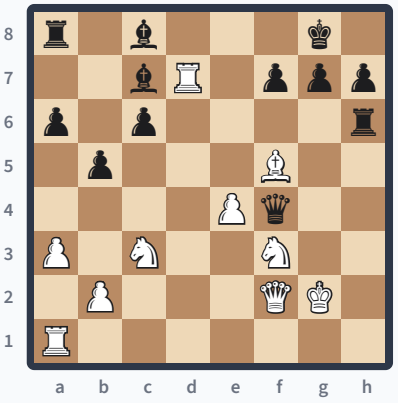
4 **Find the best quiet move for White!**



Kasparov v Gelfand
Linares 1991

Answer:

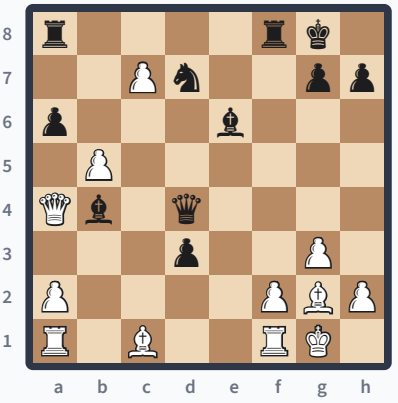
5 **Find the best quiet move for White!**



Aronian v Shirov
Shanghai Masters 2010

Answer:

6 **Find the best quiet move for White!**



Kramnik v Morozevich
WCh 2007

Answer:

Tip: first find the plan for this structure, then check the tactics that serve it.

Score: ____ / 6

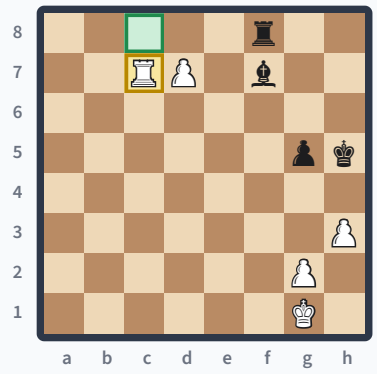
TWO WEAKNESSES

One weakness can be defended; two usually cannot

Lesson 15 · Strategy
Level 4 Strategy

1. Alekhine–Tartakower

SECOND FRONT

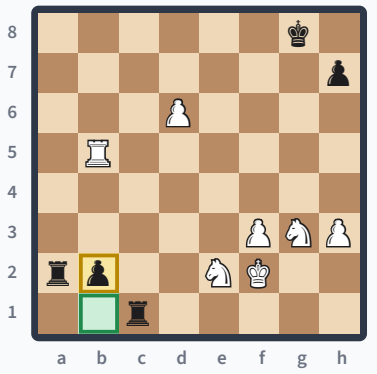


```
40.Rc8 Be6 41.Rxf8
```

- White is better in the endgame: stretch the defence.
- **40.Rc8!** 40...Be6 41.Rxf8, winning 4 points.
- Alekhine v Tartakower, Dresden 1926

2. Bronstein–Beliavsky

SECOND FRONT

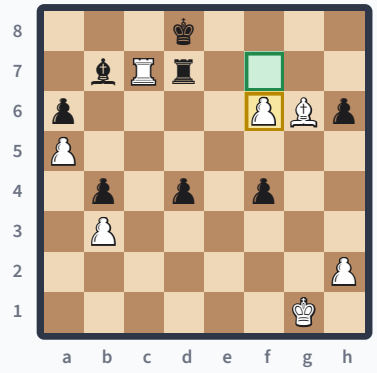


```
47...b1=Q 48.Rxb1 Rxb1
```

- Black is better in the endgame: stretch the defence.
- **47...b1=Q!** 48.Rxb1 Rxb1, winning 4 points.
- Bronstein v Beliavsky, URS-ch sf 1983

3. Alekhine–Bogoljubow

SECOND FRONT

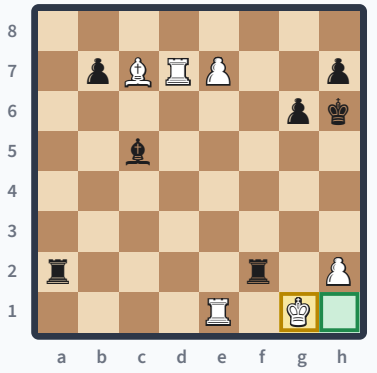


```
58.f7 Kxc7 59.f8=Q
```

- White is better in the endgame: stretch the defence.
- **58.f7!** 58...Kxc7 59.f8=Q: White is winning (engine +6.4).
- Alekhine v Bogoljubow, World Championship 15th 1934

4. Gelfand–Anand: 48.Kh1!

SECOND FRONT



```
48.Kh1 Bxe7 49.Rdxe7
```

- White is better in the endgame: stretch the defence.
- **48.Kh1!** 48...Bxe7 49.Rdxe7, winning 2 points.
- Gelfand v Anand, Manila Interzonal 1990

Stretch the Defence

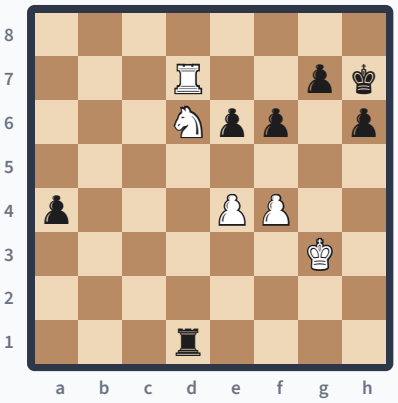
1. Tie the opponent to one weakness, then **open a second front** on the other side of the board.
2. The defender cannot cover both: the King and pieces cannot be in two places at once.
3. Don't hurry. Improve your King and pieces first, and only then switch to the second weakness.

PUZZLES: TWO WEAKNESSES

Six positions from master games

Lesson 15 · Strategy Puzzles
Level 4 Strategy

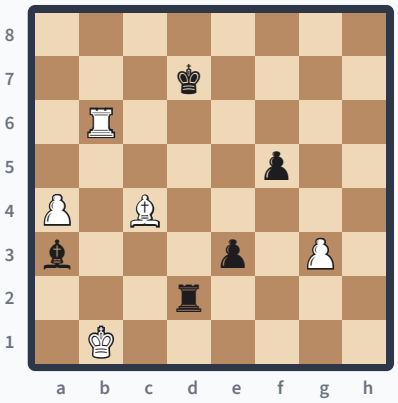
1 **Find the best move for Black!**



Geller v Polugaevsky
URS-ch31 1963

Answer:

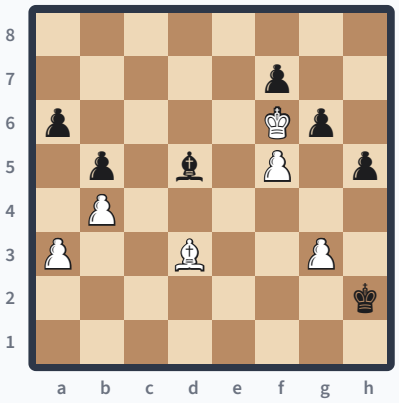
2 **Find the best move for Black!**



Beliavsky v Karpov
Tilburg 1993

Answer:

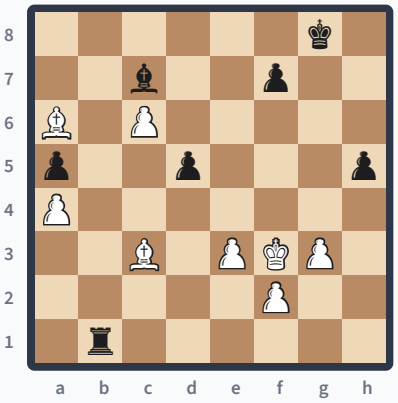
3 **Find the best move for White!**



Portisch v Larsen
Candidats qf3 1968

Answer:

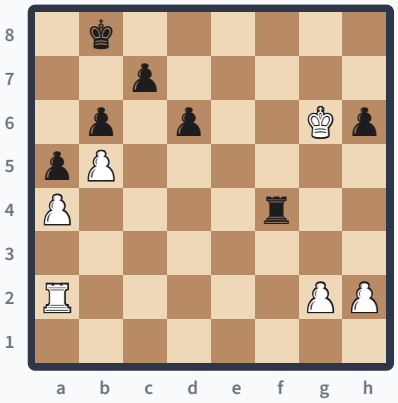
4 **Find the best move for Black!**



Bogoljubow v Alekhine
World Championship 15th 1934

Answer:

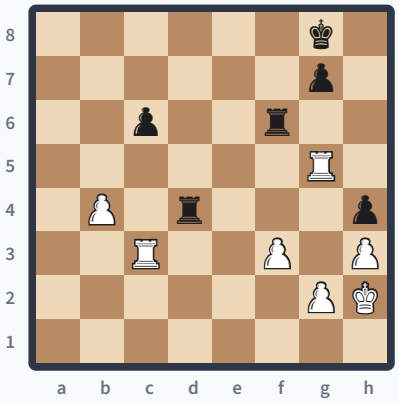
5 **Find the best move for White!**



Anand v Aronian
FIDE Candidates 2016

Answer:

6 **Find the best move for White!**



Anand v Adams
PCA-Wch Candidats sf2 1994

Answer:

Tip: first find the plan for this structure, then check the tactics that serve it.

Score: ____ / 6

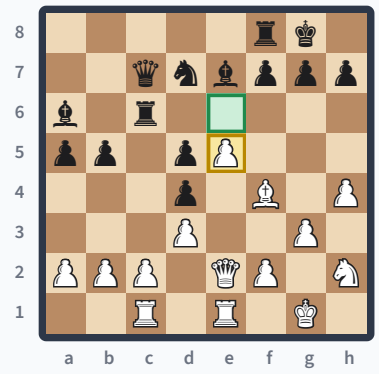
SPACE: USE IT OR LOSE IT

The side with more space manoeuvres; the cramped side looks for a break

Lesson 16 · Strategy
Level 4 Strategy

1. Fischer–Geller: 18.e6!

FREEING BREAK

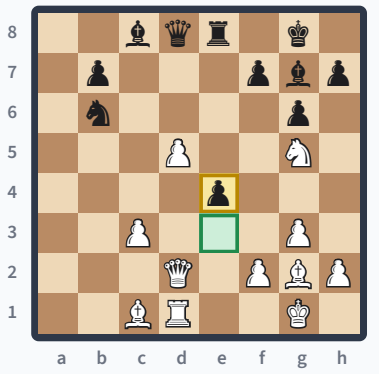


```
18.e6 Bd6 19.Bxd6
```

- White is cramped: find the pawn break that frees the position.
- **18.e6!** 18...Bd6 19.Bxd6, winning 2 points.
- Fischer v Geller, Netanya-A 1968

2. Carlsen–Giri: 20...e3!

FREEING BREAK

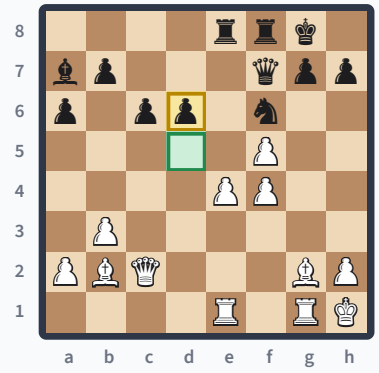


```
20...e3 21.Qd3 Qxg5
```

- Black is cramped: find the pawn break that frees the position.
- **20...e3!** 21.Qd3 Qxg5, winning 2 points.
- Carlsen v Giri, 73rd Tata Steel GMA 2011

3. Agdestein–Topalov

FREEING BREAK

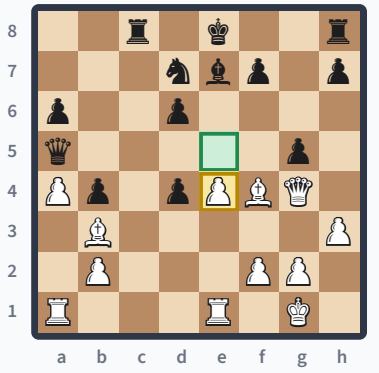


```
23...d5 24.e5 Ng4
```

- Black is cramped: find the pawn break that frees the position.
- **23...d5!** 24.e5 Ng4: Black is clearly better (engine +1.3).
- Agdestein v Topalov, 2nd Norway Chess 2014

4. Caruana–Korchnoi: 22.e5!

FREEING BREAK



```
22.e5 Kd8 23.exd6
```

- White is cramped: find the pawn break that frees the position.
- **22.e5!** 22...Kd8 23.exd6, winning 1 point.
- Caruana v Korchnoi, 38th Olympiad 2008

Space Advantage and Cramped Positions

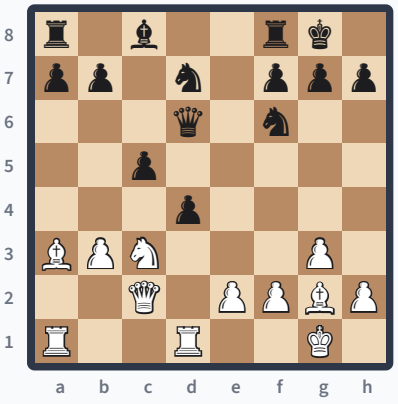
1. **More space:** avoid trades and use the room behind your pawns to switch pieces from wing to wing.
2. **Less space:** trade pieces, then free yourself with a pawn break at the base of the enemy chain.
3. Space only counts if you can use it; over-extended pawns become targets.

PUZZLES: SPACE: USE IT OR LOSE IT

Six positions from master games

Lesson 16 · Strategy Puzzles
Level 4 Strategy

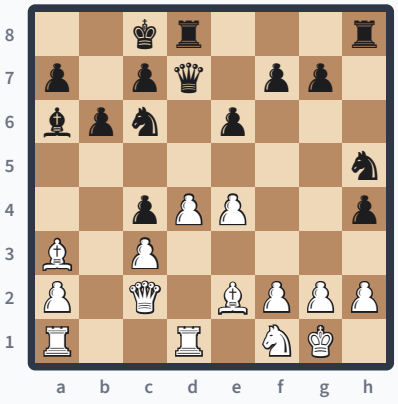
1 Find the freeing break for White!



Giri v Caruana
75th Tata Steel GpA 2013

Answer:

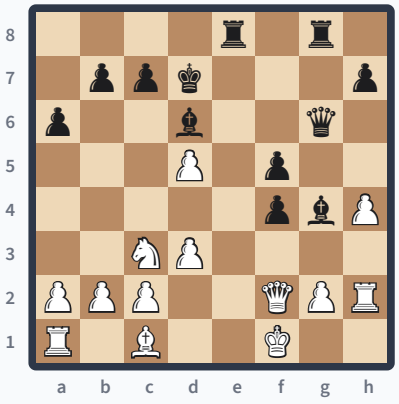
2 Find the freeing break for White!



Portisch v Fischer
Siegen olm 1970

Answer:

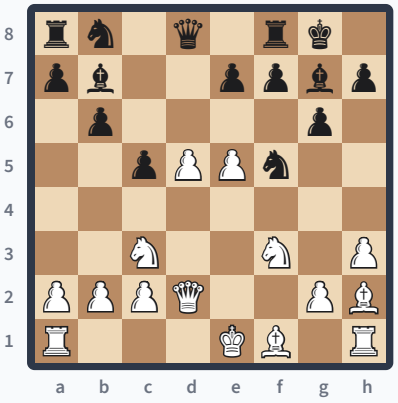
3 Find the freeing break for Black!



Anderssen v Morphy
Paris m1 1858

Answer:

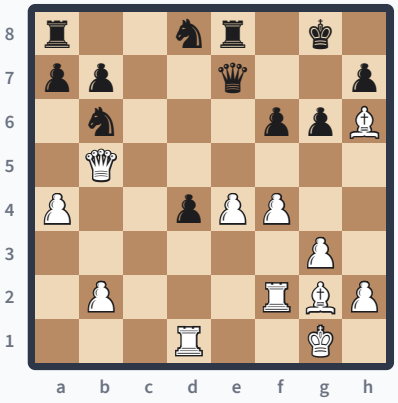
4 Find the freeing break for Black!



Beliavsky v Anand
Munich 1991

Answer:

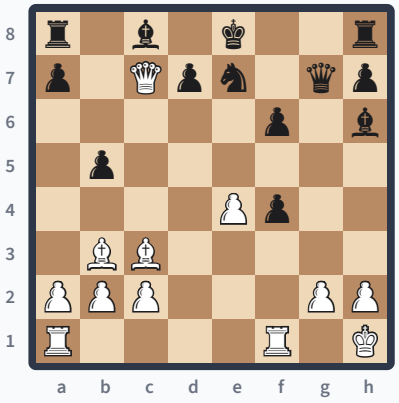
5 Find the freeing break for White!



Bogoljubow v Maroczy
Bad Sliac 1932

Answer:

6 Find the freeing break for White!



Steinitz v Anderssen
London mt 1862

Answer:

Tip: first find the plan for this structure, then check the tactics that serve it.

Score: ____ / 6

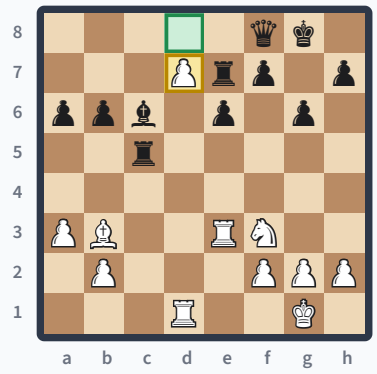
TIMING THE CENTRAL BREAK

The right pawn push at the right moment

Lesson 17 · Strategy
Level 4 Strategy

1. Smyslov–Karpov: 29.d8=Q!

PAWN BREAK

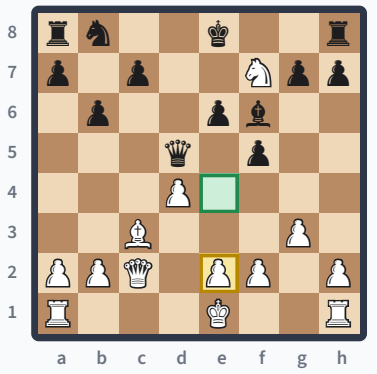


```
29.d8=Q Qxd8 30.Rxd8+
```

- White strikes in the centre with a pawn.
- **29.d8=Q!** 29...Qxd8 30.Rxd8+, winning 8 points.
- Smyslov v Karpov, URS-ch39 1971

2. Aronian–Navara: 14.e4!

PAWN BREAK

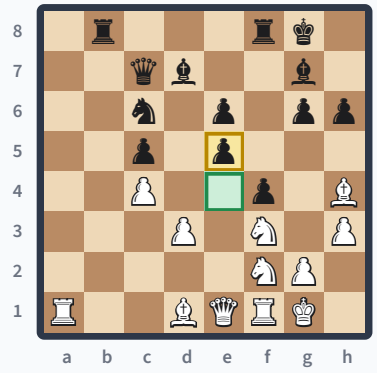


```
14.e4 fxe4 15.Nxh8
```

- White strikes in the centre with a pawn.
- **14.e4!** 14...fxe4 15.Nxh8, winning 4 points.
- Aronian v Navara, 37th Olympiad 2006

3. Polgar–Gelfand: 23...e4!

PAWN BREAK

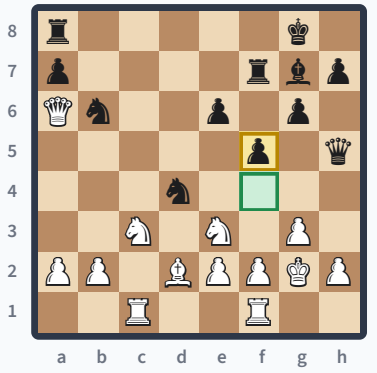


```
23...e4 24.Qxe4 Bxa1
```

- Black strikes in the centre with a pawn.
- **23...e4!** 24.Qxe4 Bxa1: Black keeps an edge (engine +0.4).
- Polgar v Gelfand, It 2000

4. Adams–Anand: 20...f4!

PAWN BREAK



```
20...f4 21.gxf4 Rxf4
```

- Black strikes in the centre with a pawn.
- **20...f4!** 21.gxf4 Rxf4: Black is clearly better (engine +1.9).
- Adams v Anand, 5th Classic GpA 2013

Before You Break

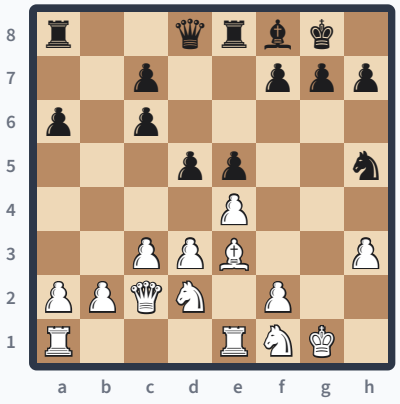
1. Break when your pieces are ready and the opponent's are not: count who benefits from the open lines.
2. Typical breaks: d4-d5, e4-e5 and c4-c5 for White; ...d5, ...e5, ...c5 and ...f5 for Black.
3. A break that opens lines towards your own uncastled King, or leaves a weak pawn, is usually too early.

PUZZLES: TIMING THE CENTRAL BREAK

Six positions from master games

Lesson 17 · Strategy Puzzles
Level 4 Strategy

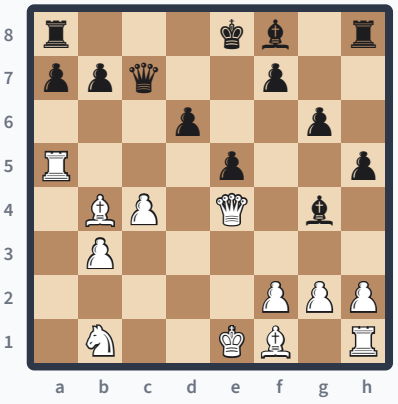
1 Find the right pawn break for Black!



Caruana v Harikrishna
75th Tata Steel GpA 2013

Answer:

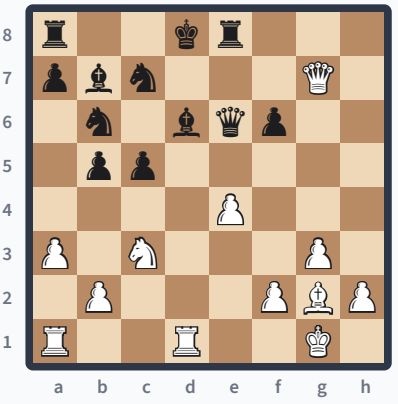
2 Find the right pawn break for Black!



Bernstein v Larsen
Amsterdam olm 1954

Answer:

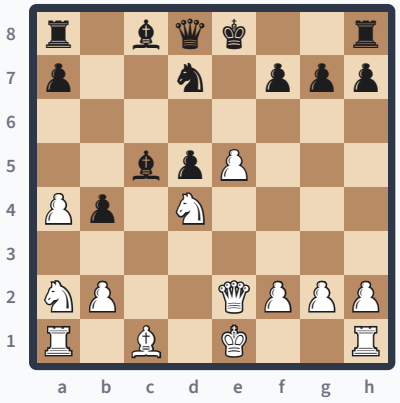
3 Find the right pawn break for White!



Radjabov v Leko
XXV SuperGM 2008

Answer:

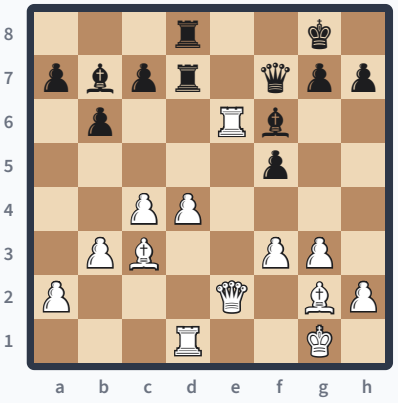
4 Find the right pawn break for White!



Tartakower v Maroczy
Folkestone ol 1933

Answer:

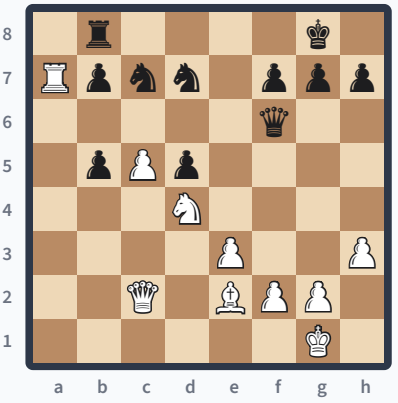
5 Find the right pawn break for Black!



Larsen v Andersson
Mar del Plata 1982

Answer:

6 Find the right pawn break for White!



Keres v Bronstein
Moscow 1967

Answer:

Tip: first find the plan for this structure, then check the tactics that serve it.

Score: ____ / 6

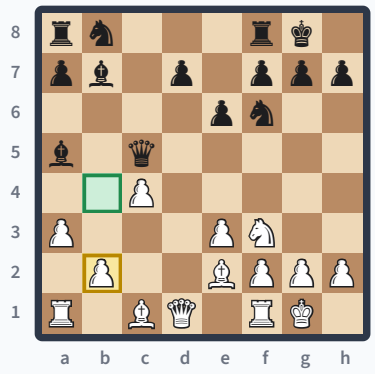
PAWN SACRIFICES FOR TIME

Give a pawn, gain time and the initiative

Lesson 18 · Strategy
Level 4 Strategy

1. Timman–Keres: 12.b4!

GAMBIT IDEA

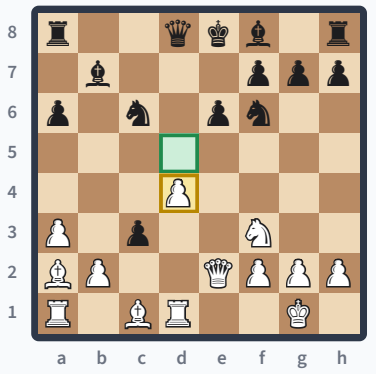


`12.b4 Qh5 13.bxa5`

- White offers a pawn on **b4** for time and open lines. Quiet Nd4 gives a worse game (-3.4).
- **12.b4!** 12...Qh5 13.bxa5: White keeps an edge (engine +0.8).
- If taken: 12...Bxb4 13.axb4 Qb6 (+1.9 for White).
- Timman v Keres, IBM 1971

2. Gelfand–Leko: 13.d5!

GAMBIT IDEA

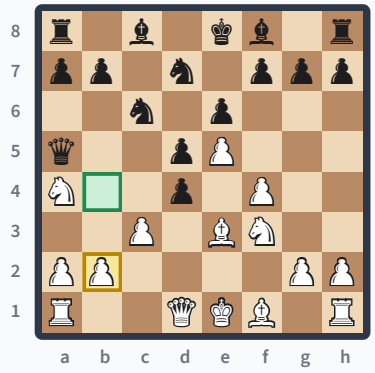


`13.d5 Nxd5 14.Rxd5`

- White offers a pawn on **d5** for time and open lines. Quiet bxc3 gives a worse game (-2.6).
- **13.d5!** 13...Nxd5 14.Rxd5: the only move to hold the balance.
- Gelfand v Leko, 43rd Olympiad 2018

3. Bronstein–Portisch

GAMBIT IDEA

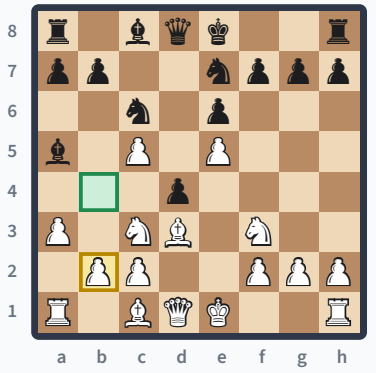


`10.b4 Nxb4 11.cxb4`

- White offers a pawn on **b4** for time and open lines. Quiet Nxd4 gives a worse game (-0.9).
- **10.b4!** 10...Nxb4 11.cxb4: White keeps an edge (engine +0.7).
- Bronstein v Portisch, Amsterdam Interzonal 1964

4. Fine–Botvinnik: 9.b4!

GAMBIT IDEA



`9.b4 Nxb4 10.axb4`

- White offers a pawn on **b4** for time and open lines. Quiet Ng5 gives a worse game (-2.5).
- **9.b4!** 9...Nxb4 10.axb4: White keeps an edge (engine +0.7).
- Fine v Botvinnik, AVRO 1938

When Is a Pawn Worth Giving?

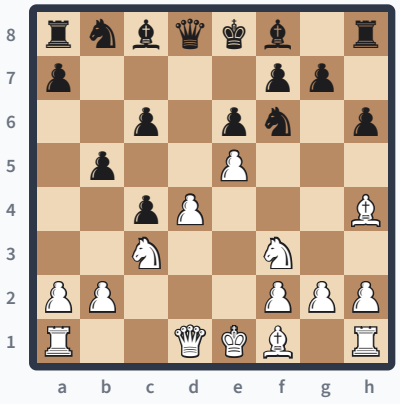
1. Give a pawn when you gain **two or more tempi**, open lines to the enemy King, or stop it castling.
2. Use the time at once: develop, castle and open the centre before the opponent catches up.
3. Accepting a gambit is fine if you give the pawn back at the right moment (Lesson 19).

PUZZLES: PAWN SACRIFICES FOR TIME

Six positions from master games

Lesson 18 · Strategy Puzzles
Level 4 Strategy

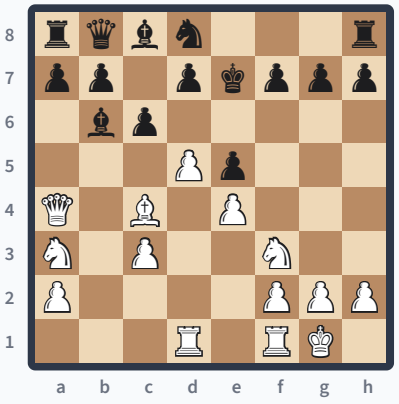
1 **Black to move. Sacrifice a pawn?**



Kramnik v Aronian
World Teams 2013

Answer:

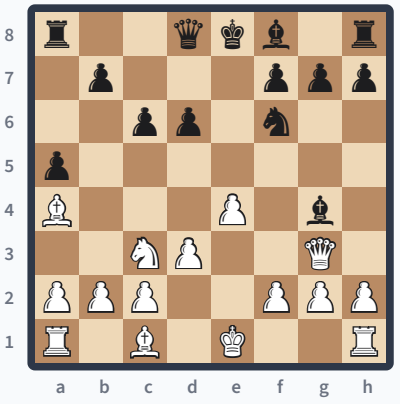
2 **White to move. Sacrifice a pawn?**



Chigorin v Steinitz
World Championship 2nd 1889

Answer:

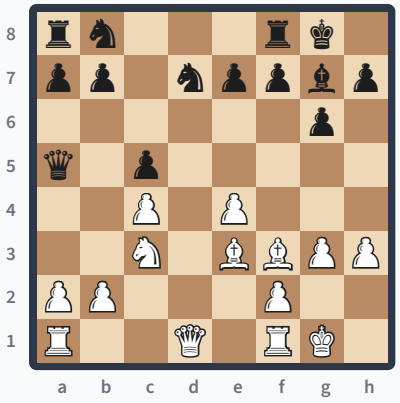
3 **Black to move. Sacrifice a pawn?**



Vallejo Pons v Giri
TCh-ESP CECLUB Honor 2013

Answer:

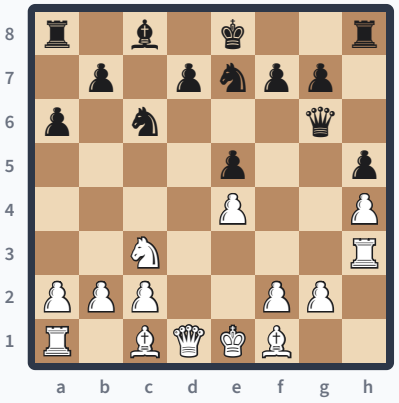
4 **White to move. Sacrifice a pawn?**



Botvinnik v Larsen
Monte Carlo 1968

Answer:

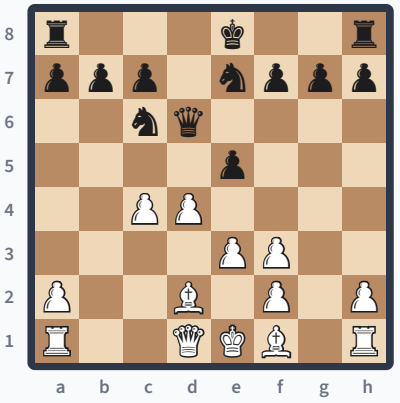
5 **Black to move. Sacrifice a pawn?**



Geller v Bronstein
Kislovodsk 1968

Answer:

6 **White to move. Sacrifice a pawn?**



Grischuk v Carlsen
73rd Tata Steel GMA 2011

Answer:

Tip: first find the plan for this structure, then check the tactics that serve it.

Score: ____ / 6

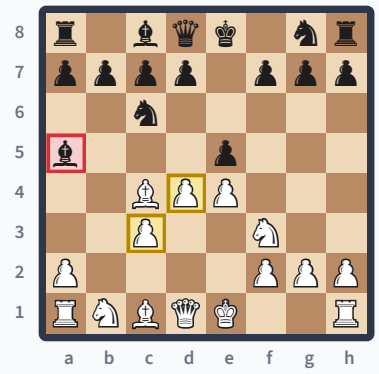
THE EVANS GAMBIT

4.b4!? A pawn for d4 with tempo

Lesson 19 · Openings
Level 4 Openings

1. The Gambit

4.B4!?



```
1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4 Bc5 4.b4 Bxb4
5.c3 Ba5 6.d4
```

- The b-pawn lures the Bishop away, so **c3 and d4** come with tempo.
- White gets a big centre and fast development for one pawn.

2. Accepted: Castle and Go

7.O-O

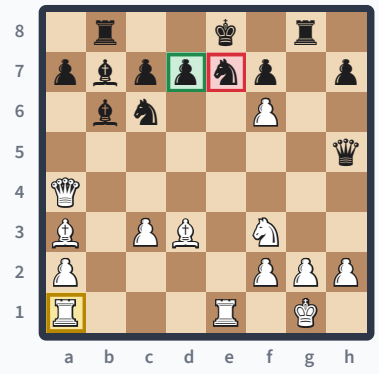


```
6...exd4 7.O-O
```

- White castles and leaves d4 hanging: development and open lines matter more than the pawn.
- Ideas: **Qb3** (hitting f7), **Ba3** (stopping ...O-O), and e4-e5.

3. Anderssen–Dufresne, 1852

THE EVERGREEN

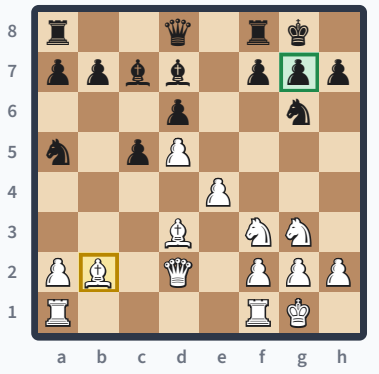


```
19.Rad1!! Qxf3 20.Rxe7+ Nxe7 21.Qxd7+!!
Kxd7 22.Bf5+ … 24.Bxe7#
```

- Every white piece is out, and the black King is still in the centre: exactly what the Evans aims for.
- **19.Rad1!!** ignores the threat and mates.
- Anderssen v Dufresne, Berlin 1852

4. Anderssen–Steinitz

EVANS GAMBIT



```
16.Bxg7 Kxg7 17.Nh5+
```

- White uses the lead in development.
- **16.Bxg7!** 16...Kxg7 17.Nh5+: White is winning (engine +5.2).
- Anderssen v Steinitz, London m1 1866

Evans Gambit: Key Ideas

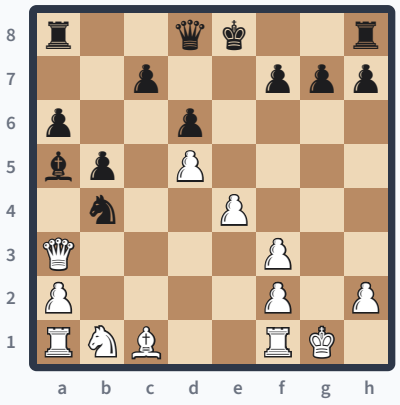
1. The b-pawn deflects the Bishop so that **c3 and d4** come with tempo (Lesson 18).
2. White develops fast (O-O, Qb3, Ba3) and aims at f7 and the uncastled King.
3. Black should return the pawn at the right moment (...d6, ...d5) instead of grabbing more.

PUZZLES: THE EVANS GAMBIT

Six positions from master games

Lesson 19 · Openings Puzzles
Level 4 Openings

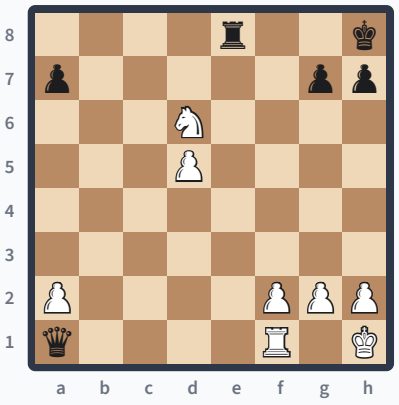
1 Find the best move for White!



Chigorin v Steinitz
World Championship 4th 1892

Answer:

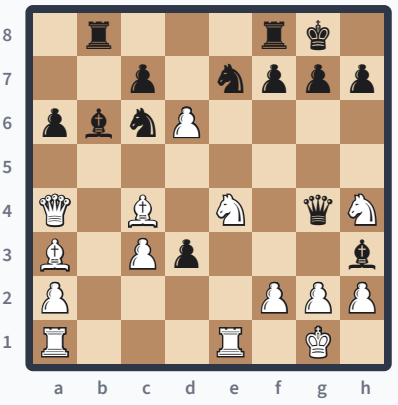
2 Find the best move for White!



Morphy v Mongredien
Paris m1 1859

Answer:

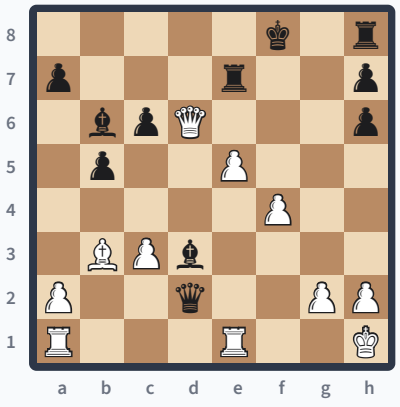
3 Find the best move for White!



Anderssen v Dufresne
Berlin m2 1855

Answer:

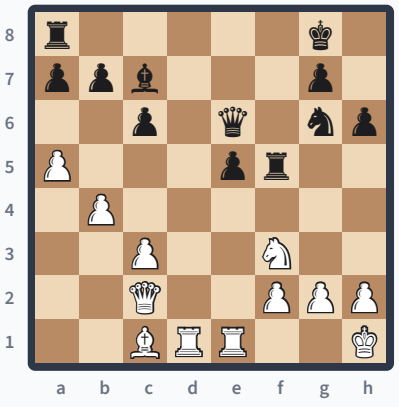
4 Find the best move for White!



Sokolsky v Bronstein
Kiev 1944

Answer:

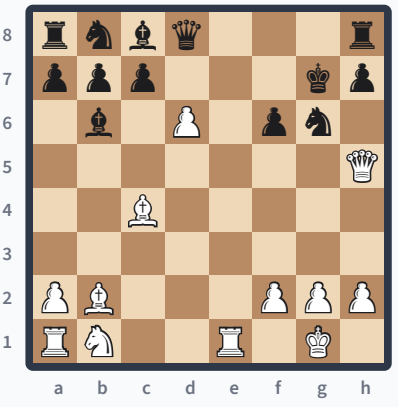
5 Find the best move for White!



Chigorin v Didier
Paris 1900

Answer:

6 Find the best move for White!



Anderssen v Mayet
Berlin m1 1865

Answer:

Tip: ask what the opening is about (a square, a file, a diagonal), then look for the move that serves it.

Score: ____ / 6

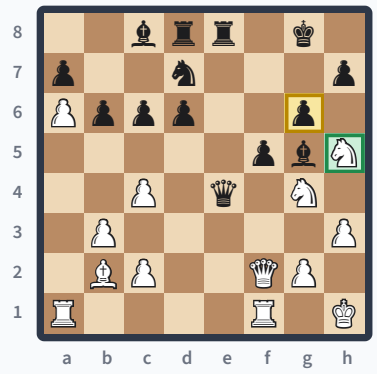
HARRY THE H-PAWN

h4-h5: the rook pawn as a battering ram

Lesson 20 · Attack
Level 4 Attack

1. Mamedyarov–Aronian

H-PAWN PUSH

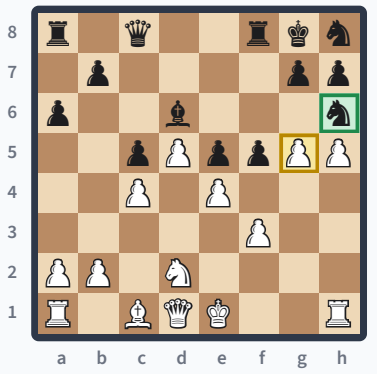


`26...gxh5 27.Qxf5 Qxf5`

- Black pushes the h-pawn at the castled King.
- **26...gxh5!** 27.Qxf5 Qxf5, winning 2 points.
- Mamedyarov v Aronian, 4th FIDE GP 2009

2. Anand–Timman: 20.gxh6!

H-PAWN PUSH

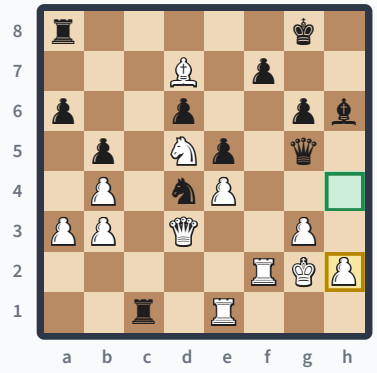


`20.gxh6 f4 21.hxg7`

- White pushes the h-pawn at the castled King.
- **20.gxh6!** 20...f4 21.hxg7, winning 3 points.
- Anand v Timman, Linares 1991

3. Carlsen–Dominguez Perez

H-PAWN PUSH

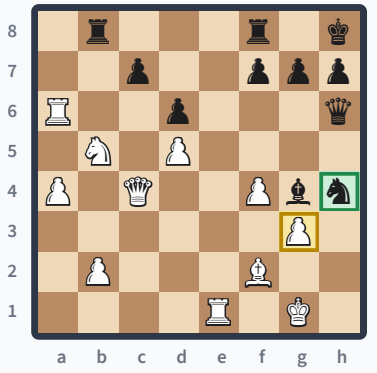


`28.h4 Qd8 29.Rxc1`

- White pushes the h-pawn at the castled King.
- **28.h4!** 28...Qd8 29.Rxc1: White is clearly better (engine +2.9).
- Carlsen v Dominguez Perez, World Cup 2007

4. Carlsen–Leko: 31.gxh4!

H-PAWN PUSH



`31.gxh4 Bd7 32.Kh2`

- White pushes the h-pawn at the castled King.
- **31.gxh4!** 31...Bd7 32.Kh2, winning 3 points.
- Carlsen v Leko, 2nd Pearl Spring 2009

Pushing the h-Pawn

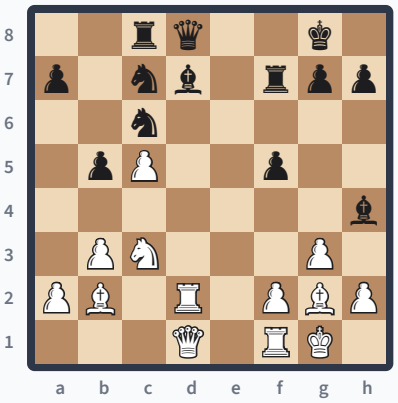
1. The h-pawn has no King behind it to expose: push it to **h5-h6** to weaken g7 or open the h-file.
2. Modern engines (AlphaZero made it famous) push the h-pawn even in quiet positions to gain space and create a hook.
3. Check first that your own King is safe and the centre is closed or stable.

PUZZLES: HARRY THE H-PAWN

Six positions from master games

Lesson 20 · Attack Puzzles
Level 4 Attack

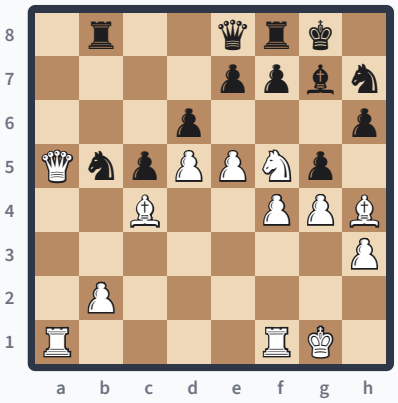
1 **White to move. Attack with the h-pawn?**



Keres v Smyslov
URS-ch15 1947

Answer:

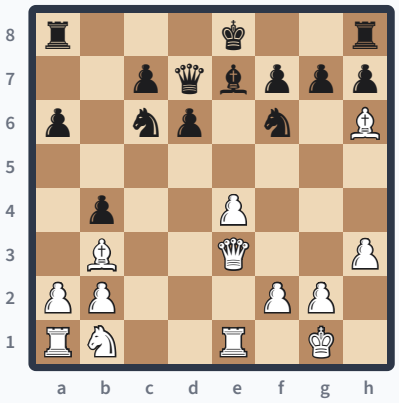
2 **Black to move. Attack with the h-pawn?**



Svidler v Nakamura
29th ECC Open 2013

Answer:

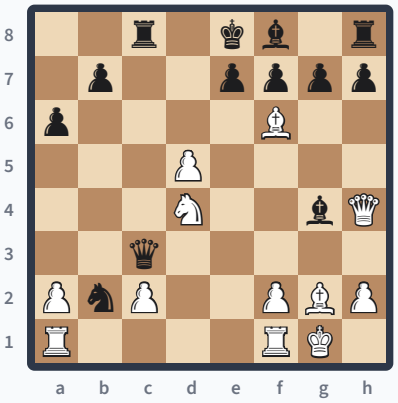
3 **Black to move. Attack with the h-pawn?**



Polgar v Short
Yerevan ol (Men) 1996

Answer:

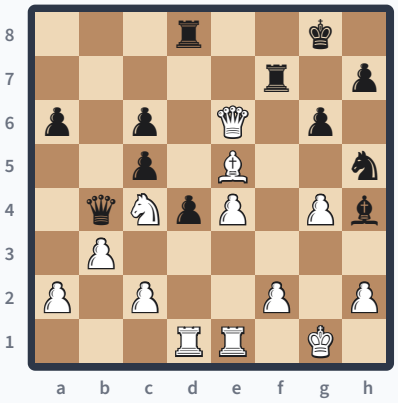
4 **Black to move. Attack with the h-pawn?**



Shirov v Ivanchuk
Linares 14th 1997

Answer:

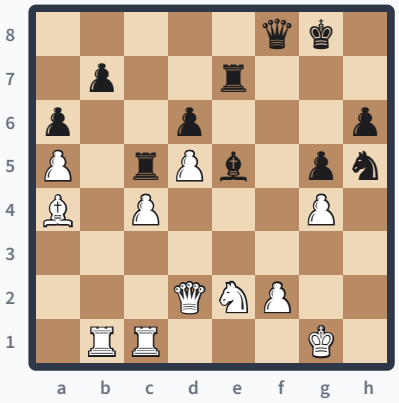
5 **White to move. Attack with the h-pawn?**



Capablanca v Marshall
USA m 1909

Answer:

6 **White to move. Attack with the h-pawn?**



Larsen v Reshevsky
Santa Monica 1966

Answer:

Tip: count the attackers near the enemy King against the defenders. More attackers? Go for it!

Score: ____ / 6

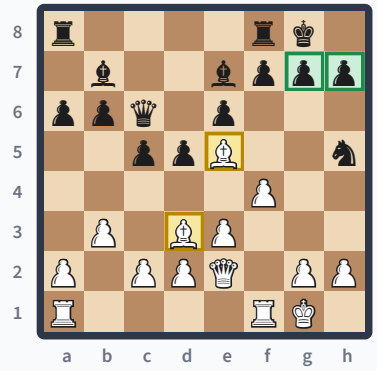
BISHOP SACRIFICES ON H7 & G7

Lasker's double sacrifice and its relatives

Lesson 21 · Attack
Level 4 Attack

1. Lasker–Bauer, 1889

THE ORIGINAL

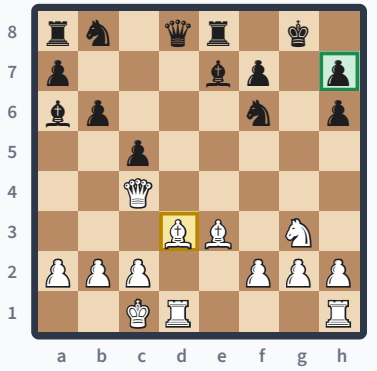


```
15.Bxh7+! Kxh7 16.Qxh5+ Kg8 17.Bxg7!!
Kxg7 18.Qg4+ Kh7 19.Rf3
```

- A Bird's Opening (Lesson 10): the b2-Bishop and the e5-square did the preparation.
- Both Bishops go: **15.Bxh7+!** and **17.Bxg7!!**, then the Rook lift Rf3-h3 wins the Queen.
- Lasker v Bauer, Amsterdam 1889

2. Alekhine–Tartakower

BISHOP SAC

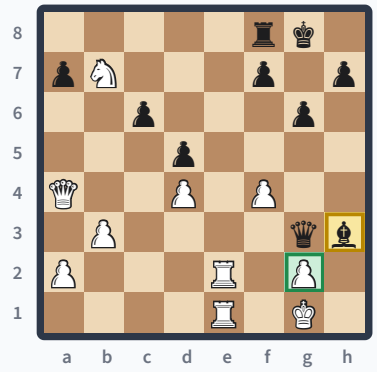


```
15.Bxh7+ Kh8 16.Qxf7
```

- The Bishop removes the h7-pawn, the King's shield. Quiet Qc3 gives only equality (-0.4).
- **15.Bxh7+!** 15...Kh8 16.Qxf7, winning 2 points.
- If taken: 15...Nxh7 16.Qg4+ Bg5 (+5.7 for White).
- Alekhine v Tartakower, Kecskemet-A 1927

3. Alekhine–Maroczy

BISHOP SAC

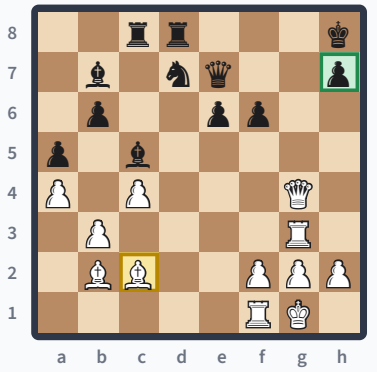


```
31...Bxg2 32.b4 Bf3+
```

- The Bishop removes the g2-pawn, the King's shield. Quiet Kg7 gives a worse game (-4.8).
- **31...Bxg2!** 32.b4 Bf3+, winning 1 point.
- If taken: 32.Rxg2 Qxe1+ 33.Kh2 (+5.9 for Black).
- Alekhine v Maroczy, London 1922

4. Alekhine–Bogoljubow

BISHOP SAC



```
24.Bxh7 Qxh7 25.Rh3
```

- The Bishop removes the h7-pawn, the King's shield. Quiet Rd1 gives a worse game (-3.0).
- **24.Bxh7!** 24...Qxh7 25.Rh3: White is clearly better (engine +1.4).
- Alekhine v Bogoljubow, World Championship 15th 1934

The Lasker Pattern

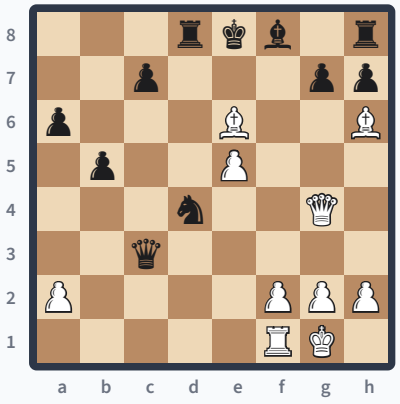
1. Both Bishops sacrifice themselves on **h7 and g7**, stripping the King of its pawn cover.
2. The Queen then checks (Qg4+ or Qh5+) and a Rook lift (Rf3-h3) usually finishes the job.
3. Check first: is the Queen ready to follow up, and is there a Rook to join?

PUZZLES: BISHOP SACRIFICES ON H7 & G7

Six positions from master games

Lesson 21 · Attack Puzzles
Level 4 Attack

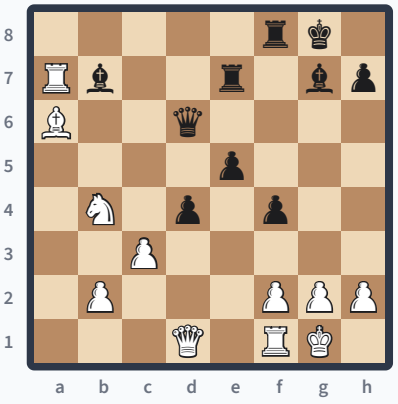
1 Find the best move for White!



Kasparov v Anand
PCA-World Championship 1995

Answer:

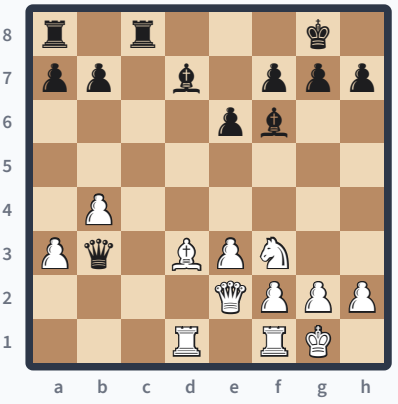
2 Find the best move for Black!



Anand v Leko
Corus A 2005

Answer:

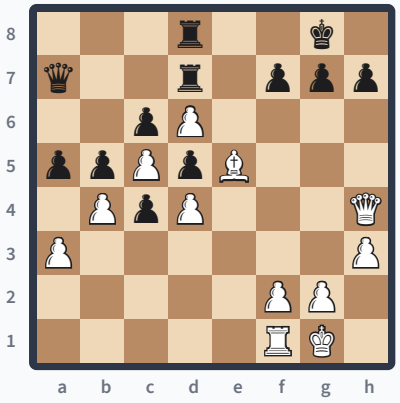
3 Find the best move for White!



Rubinstein v Capablanca
Berlin Tageblatt 1928

Answer:

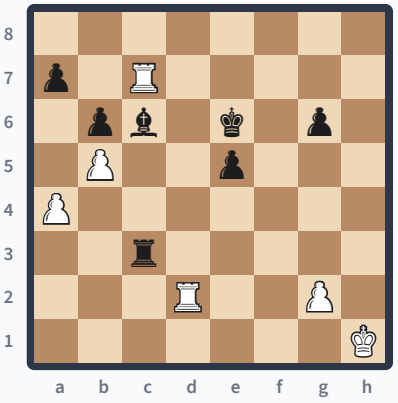
4 Find the best move for White!



Ding v Aronian
Alekhine Mem 2013

Answer:

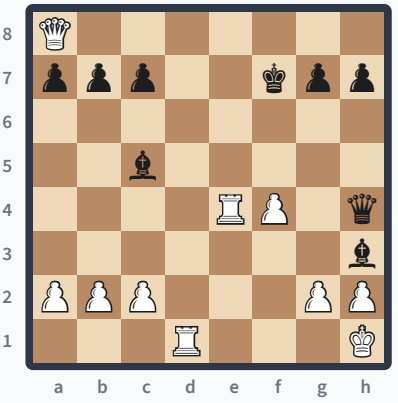
5 Find the best move for Black!



Caruana v Mamedyarov
Superbet Classic 2021

Answer:

6 Find the best move for Black!



Euwe v Reti
Amsterdam m 1920

Answer:

Tip: count the attackers near the enemy King against the defenders. More attackers? Go for it!

Score: ____ / 6

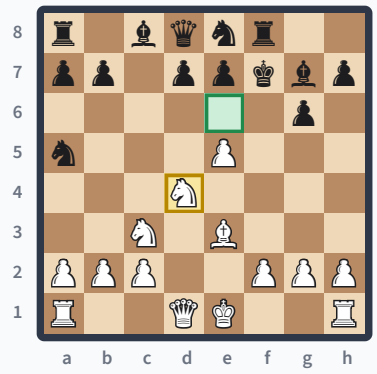
KNIGHT SACRIFICES: D5, F5, E6

Classic Sicilian Knight sacrifices

Lesson 22 · Attack
Level 4 Attack

1. Fischer–Reshevsky

KNIGHT SAC

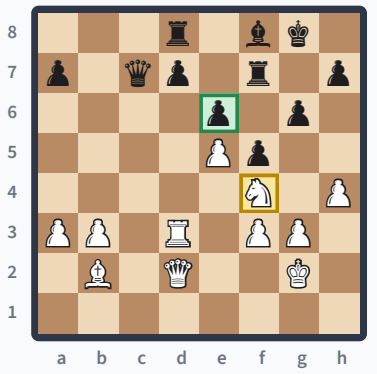


```
11.Ne6 dxe6 12.Qxd8
```

- The Knight goes to **e6** to open the f-file and the a2-g8 diagonal. Quiet h4 gives a worse game (-2.3).
- **11.Ne6!** 11...dxe6 12.Qxd8, winning 6 points.
- Fischer v Reshevsky, USA-ch 1958

2. Botvinnik–Capablanca

KNIGHT SAC

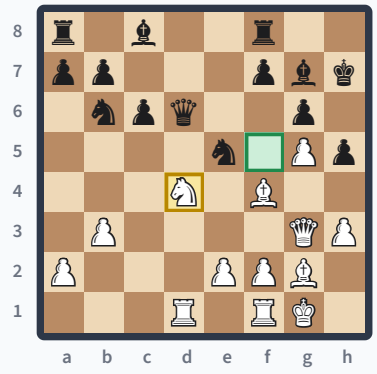


```
29.Nxe6 dxe6 30.Rxd8
```

- The Knight goes to **e6** to open the f-file and the a2-g8 diagonal. Quiet h5 gives a worse game (-1.9).
- **29.Nxe6!** 29...dxe6 30.Rxd8, winning 3 points.
- Botvinnik v Capablanca, Moscow 1936

3. Keres–Petrosian: 22.Nf5!

KNIGHT SAC

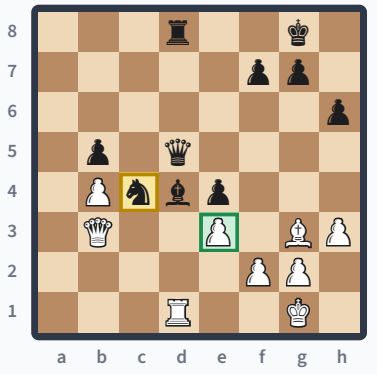


```
22.Nf5 Qc5 23.Nxg7
```

- The Knight goes to **f5** to open lines around the King. Quiet Nxc6 gives a worse game (-2.3).
- **22.Nf5!** 22...Qc5 23.Nxg7, winning 3 points.
- If taken: 22...gxf5 23.Rxd6 Ng6 (+4.8 for White).
- Keres v Petrosian, URS-ch17 1949

4. Capablanca–Alekhine

KNIGHT SAC



```
32...Nxe3 33.Rxd4 Qxd4
```

- The Knight goes to **e3** to open the f-file and the a2-g8 diagonal. Quiet Qg5 gives only +1.4.
- **32...Nxe3!** 33.Rxd4 Qxd4: Black is winning (engine +5.2).
- If taken: 33.Qxe3 Bxe3 34.Rxd5 (+6.3 for Black).
- Capablanca v Alekhine, World Championship 13th 1927

Why These Squares?

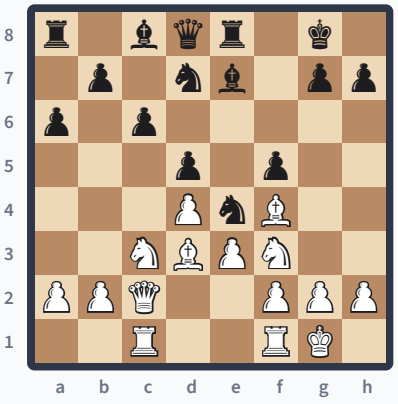
1. **Nd5:** if ...exd5, the e-file opens towards the King. **Nf5:** if ...exf5 (or ...gxf5), lines open around the King.
2. **Ne6 / Nxe6:** fxe6 opens the a2-g8 diagonal and the f-file.
3. These sacrifices work when the enemy King is still in the centre or the attackers outnumber the defenders.

PUZZLES: KNIGHT SACRIFICES: D5, F5, E6

Six positions from master games

Lesson 22 · Attack Puzzles
Level 4 Attack

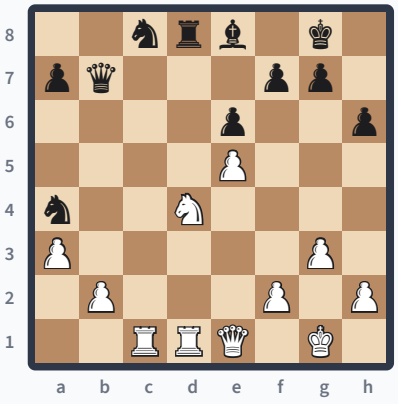
1 **White to move. Is it time for a Knight sacrifice?**



Alekhine v Rubinstein
San Remo 1930

Answer:

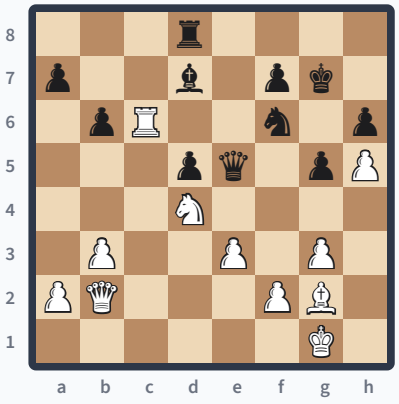
2 **White to move. Is it time for a Knight sacrifice?**



Kasparov v Timman
Belgrade 1989

Answer:

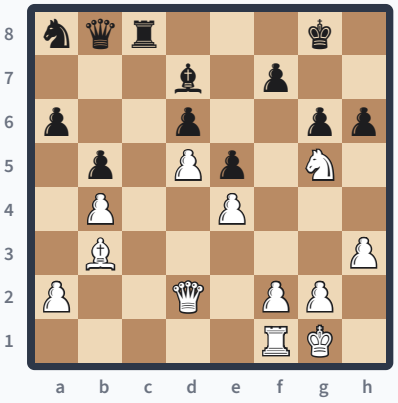
3 **White to move. Is it time for a Knight sacrifice?**



Portisch v Timman
Bugojno 1986

Answer:

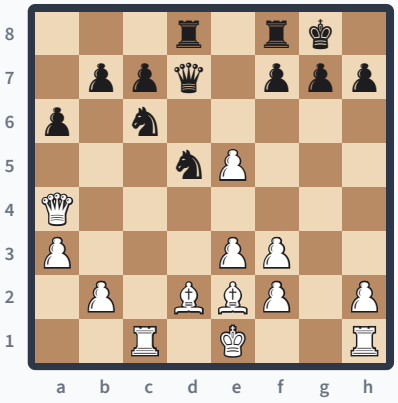
4 **White to move. Is it time for a Knight sacrifice?**



Anand v Carlsen
XXIV SuperGM 2007

Answer:

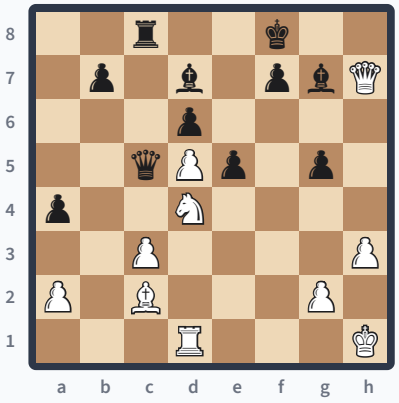
5 **Black to move. Is it time for a Knight sacrifice?**



Steinitz v Chigorin
London 1899

Answer:

6 **White to move. Is it time for a Knight sacrifice?**



Kasparov v Polgar
Corus 2000

Answer:

Tip: count the attackers near the enemy King against the defenders. More attackers? Go for it!

Score: ____ / 6

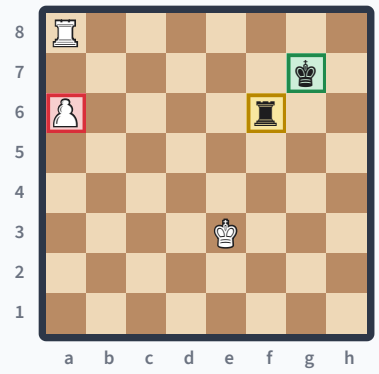
ROOK ENDGAMES

Beyond Lucena and Philidor

Lesson 23 · Endgame
Level 4 Endgame

1. The Vancura Position

ROOK FROM THE SIDE

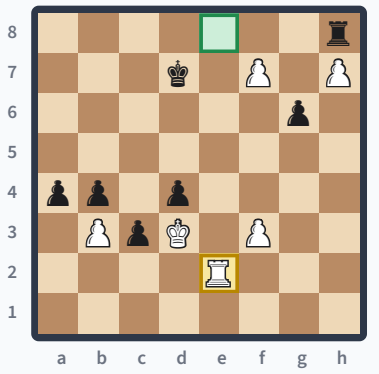


```
Draw with best play
```

- White's Rook is stuck in front of the a-pawn. Black's Rook attacks **a6** from the side, along the 6th rank.
- If the White King comes to help, the Rook checks it away. The black King stays on **g7**.

2. Ivanchuk–Shirov: 45.Re8!

ONLY MOVE

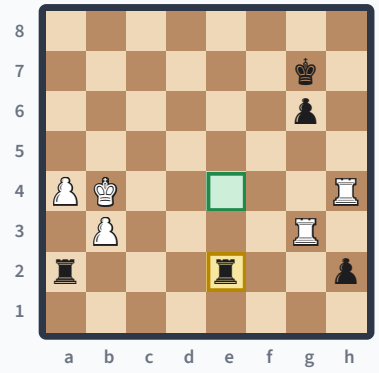


```
45.Re8 axb3 46.Rxh8
```

- Rook endgame: only one move wins.
- **45.Re8!** 45...axb3 46.Rxh8, winning 4 points.
- Ivanchuk v Shirov, Novgorod 1994

3. Anand–Aronian

ONLY MOVE

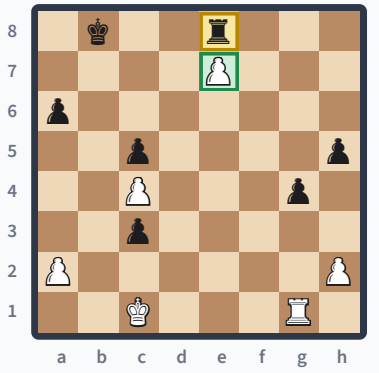


```
47...Re4+ 48.Rxe4 h1=Q
```

- Rook endgame: only one move wins.
- **47...Re4+!** 48.Rxe4 h1=Q: Black is winning (engine +4.6).
- Anand v Aronian, Grand Slam Final 2008

4. Bogoljubow–Alekhine

ONLY MOVE



```
37...Rxe7 38.Rg2 Kc7
```

- Rook endgame: only one move wins.
- **37...Rxe7!** 38.Rg2 Kc7, winning 1 point.
- Bogoljubow v Alekhine, World Championship 15th 1934

Rook Endgame Rules

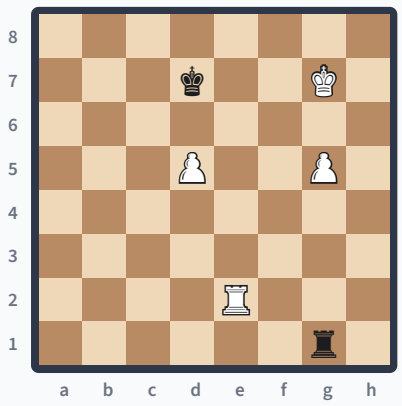
1. **Vancura:** against a Rook's pawn on the 6th, attack it from the side; the King stays near g7.
2. **Tarrasch rule:** Rooks belong **behind** passed pawns, yours and the opponent's.
3. Activity beats material: an active Rook is often worth a pawn.

PUZZLES: ROOK ENDGAMES

Six positions from master games

Lesson 23 · Endgame Puzzles
Level 4 Endgame

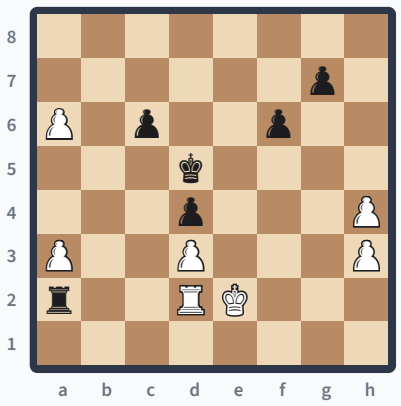
1 **Find the best move for Black!**



Mamedyarov v Carlsen
36th ECC Open 2021

Answer:

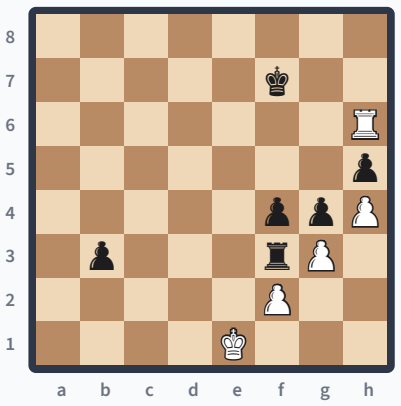
2 **Find the best move for Black!**



Flohr v Spassky
Chigorin mem 1965

Answer:

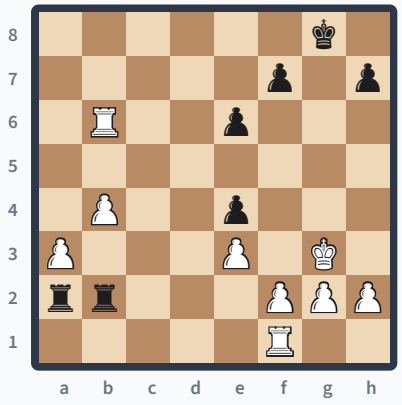
3 **Find the best move for White!**



Euwe v Alekhine
World Championship 17th 1937

Answer:

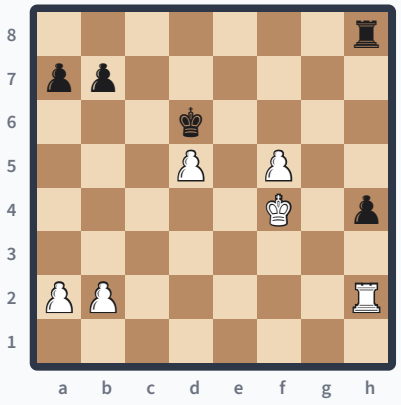
4 **Find the best move for Black!**



Capablanca v Fine
AVRO 1938

Answer:

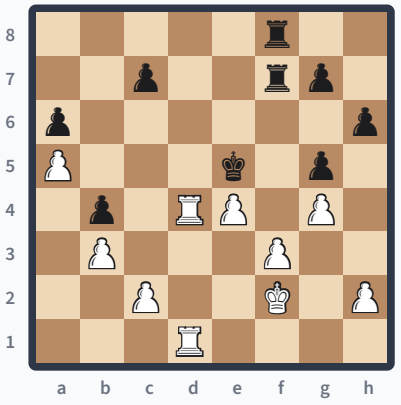
5 **Find the best move for White!**



Aronian v Nakamura
World Teams 2013

Answer:

6 **Find the best move for Black!**



Nakamura v Aronian
3rd Sinquefield Cup 2015

Answer:

Tip: Kings are fighters in the endgame. Every tempo counts!

Score: ____ / 6

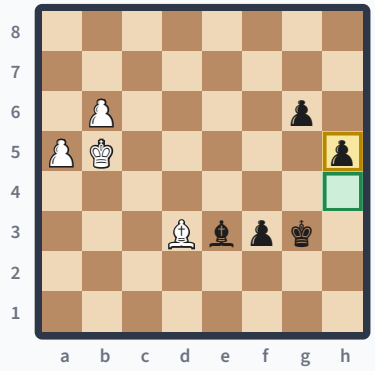
OPPOSITE-COLOURED BISHOPS

Drawish in the endgame, deadly in the middlegame

Lesson 24 · Endgame
Level 4 Endgame

1. Mamedyarov–Topalov

OPPOSITE BISHOPS

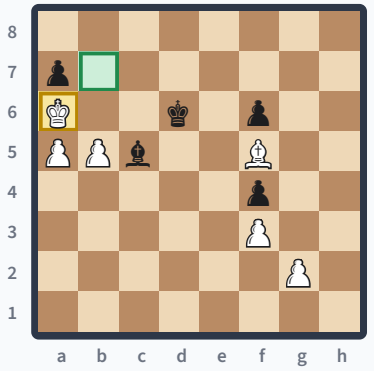


`56...h4 57.a6 h3`

- Opposite-coloured Bishops: only one move holds.
- **56...h4!** 57.a6 h3: the only move to hold the balance.
- Mamedyarov v Topalov, 10th Norway Chess 2022

2. Rozentalis–Andersson

OPPOSITE BISHOPS

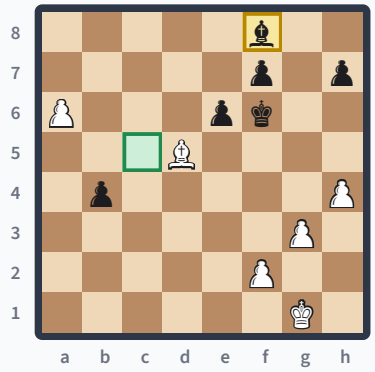


`62.Kb7 Bd4 63.Bc2`

- Opposite-coloured Bishops: only one move wins.
- **62.Kb7!** 62...Bd4 63.Bc2: White is winning (engine +5.9).
- Rozentalis v Andersson, Tilburg 1993

3. Aronian–Nakamura

OPPOSITE BISHOPS

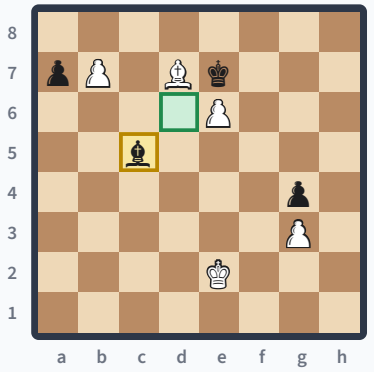


`30...Bc5 31.Be4 h6`

- Opposite-coloured Bishops: only one move holds.
- **30...Bc5!** 31.Be4 h6: the only move to hold the balance.
- Aronian v Nakamura, Nakamura-Aronian m 2014

4. Aronian–Vachier Lagrave

OPPOSITE BISHOPS



`59...Bd6 60.Kf2 a5`

- Opposite-coloured Bishops: only one move holds.
- **59...Bd6!** 60.Kf2 a5: the only move to hold the balance.
- Aronian v Vachier Lagrave, FIDE World Cup 2017

Opposite-Coloured Bishops

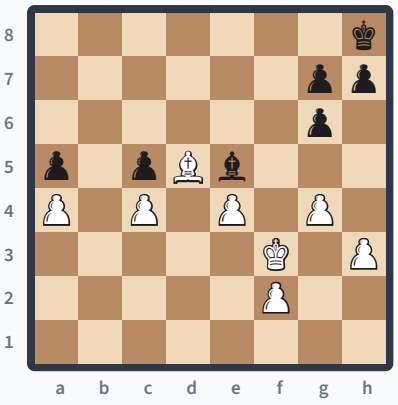
1. **Defender:** blockade on the squares your Bishop controls; even two pawns down is often a draw.
2. **Attacker:** you need passed pawns far apart (two weaknesses) so the defending King and Bishop are overloaded.
3. In the middlegame it is the opposite: the attacking Bishop has no opponent, so attacks get stronger.

PUZZLES: OPPOSITE BISHOPS

Six positions from master games

Lesson 24 · Endgame Puzzles
Level 4 Endgame

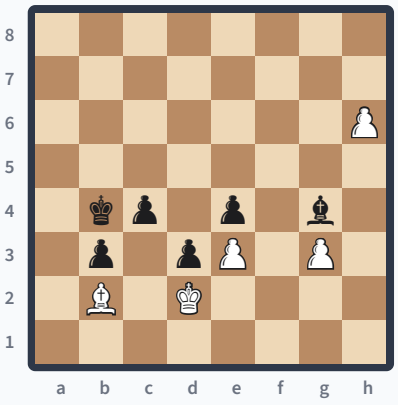
1 **Find the best move for Black!**



Carlsen v Kamsky
Tal Mem 2007

Answer:

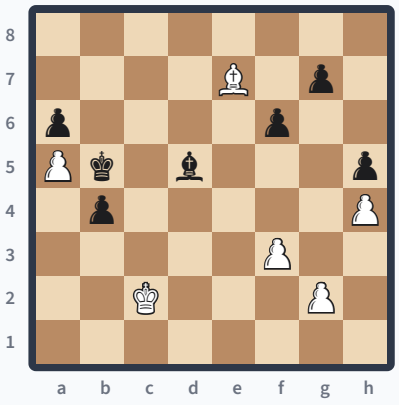
2 **Find the best move for Black!**



Grischuk v Mamedyarov
Tbilisi FIDE GP 2015

Answer:

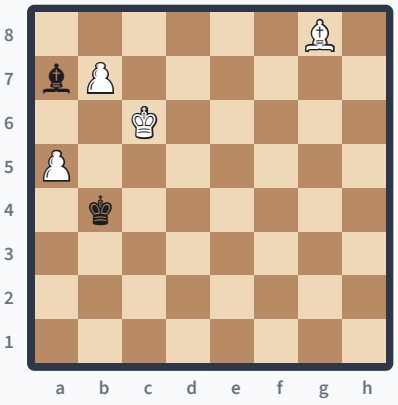
3 **Find the best move for White!**



Timman v Karpov
Las Palmas 1977

Answer:

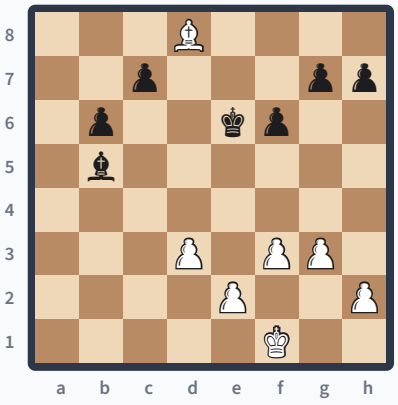
4 **Find the best move for White!**



Shirov v Kramnik
WCC cand 1998

Answer:

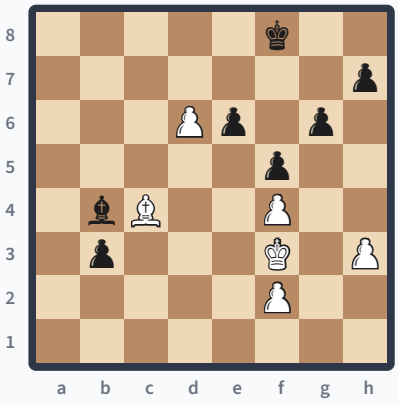
5 **Find the best move for White!**



Andersson v Hartston
Las Palmas 1974

Answer:

6 **Find the best move for Black!**



Romanishin v Anand
PCA-Wch Candidats m2 1994

Answer:

Tip: Kings are fighters in the endgame. Every tempo counts!

Score: ____ / 6

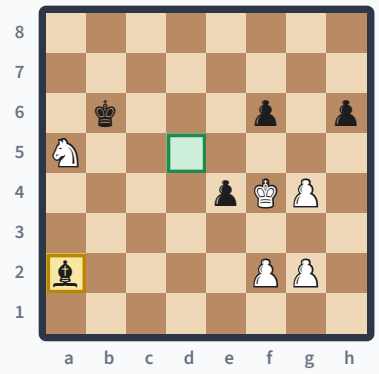
BISHOP VS KNIGHT

Which minor piece wins the endgame?

Lesson 25 · Endgame
Level 4 Endgame

1. Marshall–Nimzowitsch

MINOR PIECES

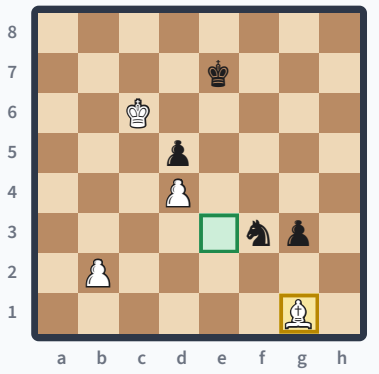


```
54...Bd5 55.Nc4+ Bxc4
```

- Bishop against Knight: only one move wins.
- **54...Bd5!** 55.Nc4+ Bxc4, winning 2 points.
- Marshall v Nimzowitsch, Berlin Tageblatt 1928

2. Caruana–Nakamura

MINOR PIECES

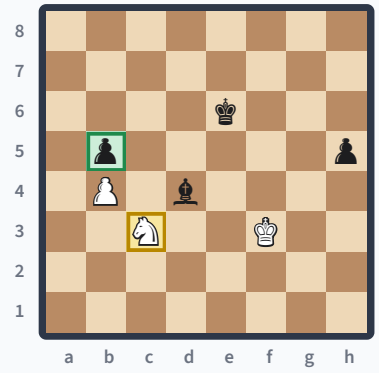


```
55.Be3 g2 56.b4
```

- Bishop against Knight: only one move holds.
- **55.Be3!** 55...g2 56.b4: the only move to hold the balance.
- Caruana v Nakamura, Corus A 2010

3. Giri–Caruana: 46.Nxb5!

MINOR PIECES

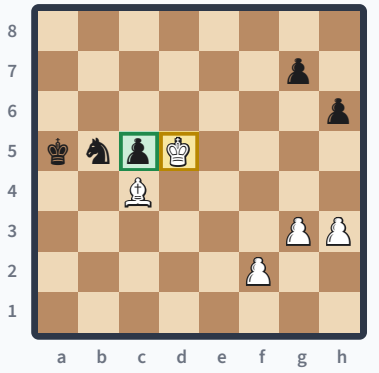


```
46.Nxb5 Be5 47.Na3
```

- Bishop against Knight: only one move holds.
- **46.Nxb5!** 46...Be5 47.Na3: the only move to hold the balance.
- Giri v Caruana, 7th Sinquefield Cup 2019

4. Timman–Larsen: 56.Kxc5!

MINOR PIECES



```
56.Kxc5 Nc3 57.Bd5
```

- Bishop against Knight: only one move wins.
- **56.Kxc5!** 56...Nc3 57.Bd5, winning 1 point.
- Timman v Larsen, Montreal 1979

Bishop or Knight?

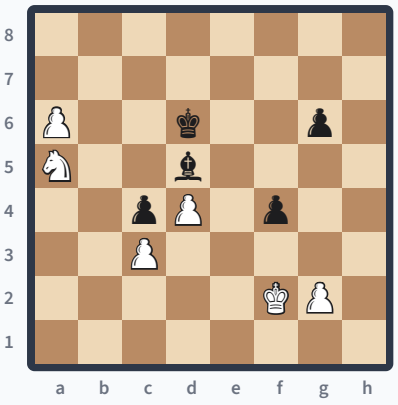
1. **Bishop** is better with pawns on both wings and an open board: it is long-range.
2. **Knight** is better with all pawns on one side, a blocked centre, or against a bad Bishop.
3. Put your pawns on the opposite colour to your Bishop, and fix the enemy pawns on its colour.

PUZZLES: BISHOP VS KNIGHT

Six positions from master games

Lesson 25 · Endgame Puzzles
Level 4 Endgame

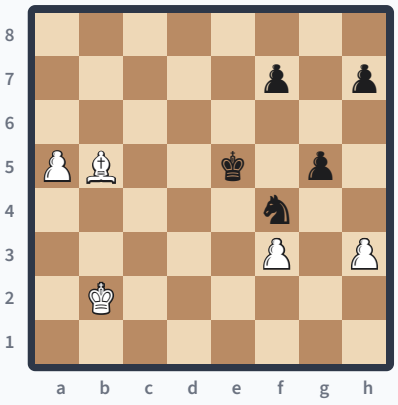
1 **Find the best move for White!**



Morozevich v Shirov
It 2001

Answer:

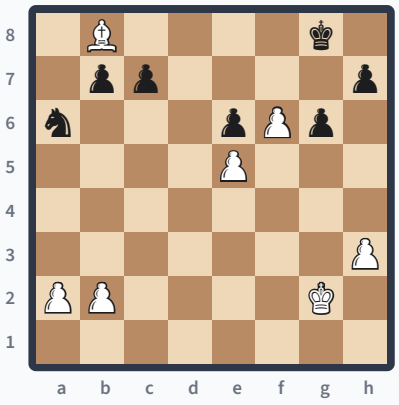
2 **Find the best move for White!**



Topalov v Aronian
Pearl Spring 2008

Answer:

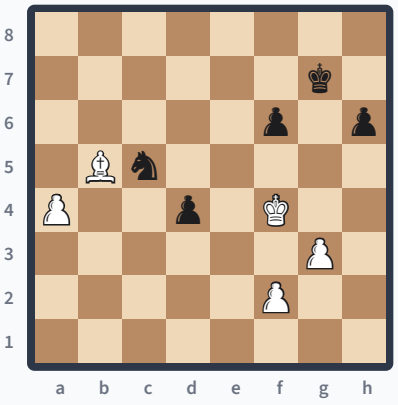
3 **Find the best move for White!**



Chigorin v Marshall
Monte Carlo 1901

Answer:

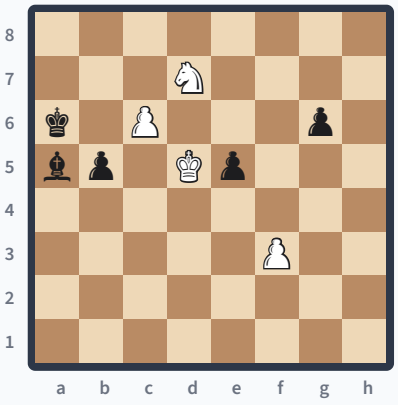
4 **Find the best move for White!**



Grischuk v Vachier Lagrave
Hamburg FIDE Grand Prix 2019

Answer:

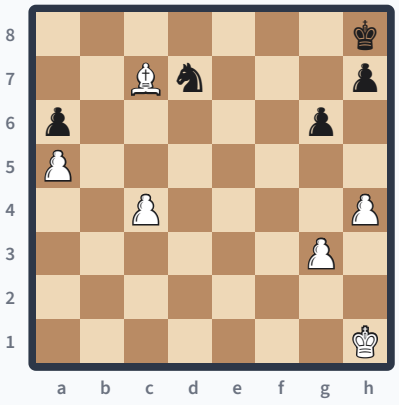
5 **Find the best move for White!**



Timman v Ivanchuk
Amsterdam VSB 1994

Answer:

6 **Find the best move for White!**



Karpov v Polugaevsky
Candidats qf1 1974

Answer:

Tip: Kings are fighters in the endgame. Every tempo counts!

Score: ____ / 6

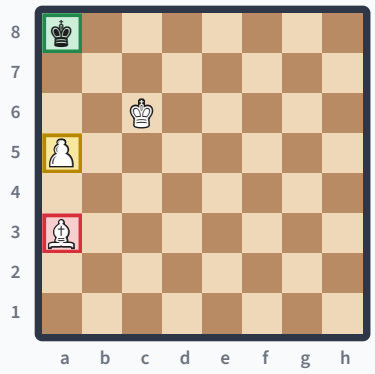
FORTRESSES

Material down, but they cannot get in

Lesson 26 · Endgame
Level 4 Endgame

1. Wrong Bishop + Rook's Pawn

DRAW

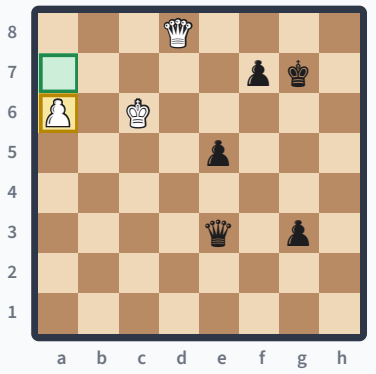


```
a8 is light; the Bishop is dark
```

- The black King sits in the corner **a8**. A dark-squared Bishop can never drive it out.
- Bishop and pawn up, White still cannot win: a classic fortress.

2. Leko–Kasparov: 69.a7!

HOLD THE DRAW

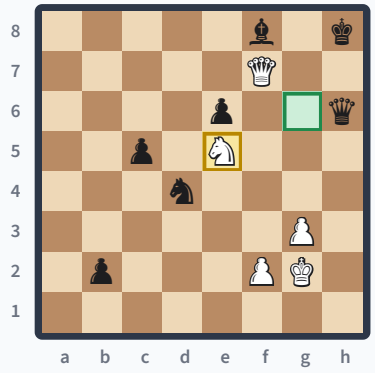


```
69.a7 Qe4+ 70.Kc7
```

- White is material down.
- **69.a7!** 69...Qe4+ 70.Kc7: the only move to hold the balance.
- Leko v Kasparov, XX SuperGM 2003

3. Karpov–Gelfand: 65.Ng6+!

HOLD THE DRAW

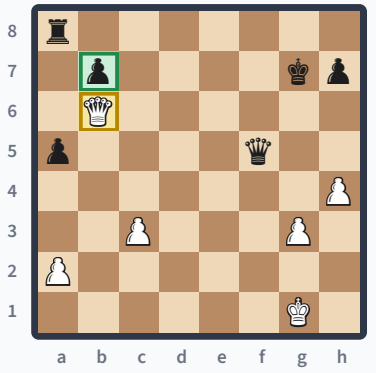


```
65.Ng6+ Qxg6 66.Qxg6
```

- White is material down.
- **65.Ng6+!** 65...Qxg6 66.Qxg6: the only move to hold the balance.
- Karpov v Gelfand, Cap d'Agde 1994

4. Mamedyarov–Caruana

HOLD THE DRAW



```
30.Qxb7+ Qf7 31.Qxa8
```

- White is material down.
- **30.Qxb7+!** 30...Qf7 31.Qxa8: the only move to hold the balance.
- Mamedyarov v Caruana, 7th Sinquefield Cup 2019

Building a Fortress

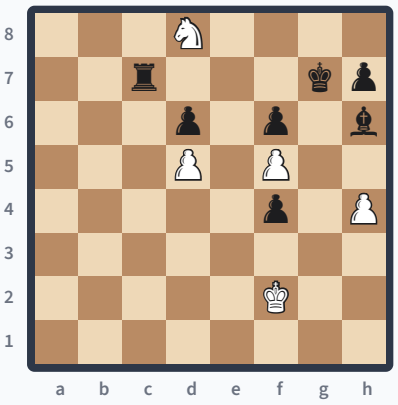
1. A fortress is a position the stronger side cannot break into, however long they try.
2. Classic fortresses: wrong-coloured Bishop + Rook's pawn, opposite-coloured Bishops, and blocked pawn chains.
3. When you are lost on material, look for a fortress before you give up.

PUZZLES: FORTRESSES

Six positions from master games

Lesson 26 · Endgame Puzzles
Level 4 Endgame

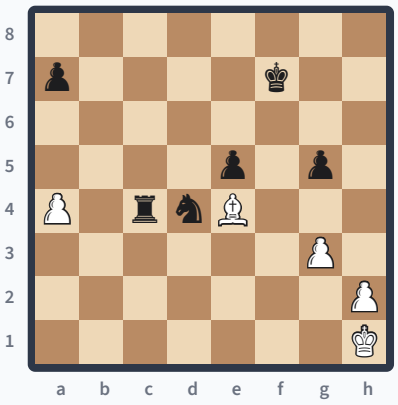
1 **White is material down. Find the move that holds!**



Kramnik v Timman
Linares 1993

Answer:

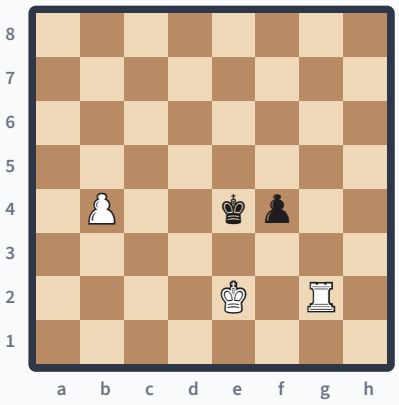
2 **White is material down. Find the move that holds!**



Kamsky v Kramnik
PCA-Wch Candidats m4 1994

Answer:

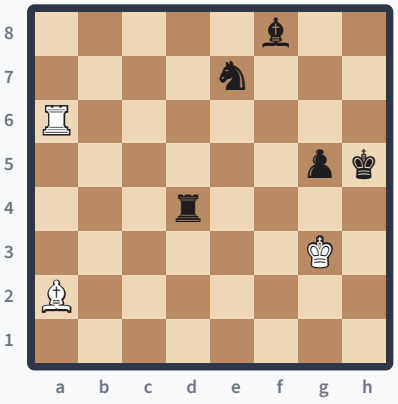
3 **Black is material down. Find the move that holds!**



Adams v Mamedyarov
FIDE GP 2008

Answer:

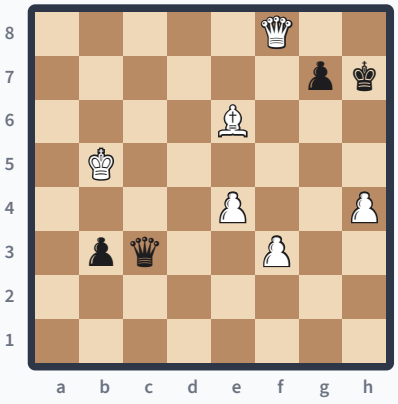
4 **White is material down. Find the move that holds!**



Aronian v Nakamura
Tal Memorial 2010

Answer:

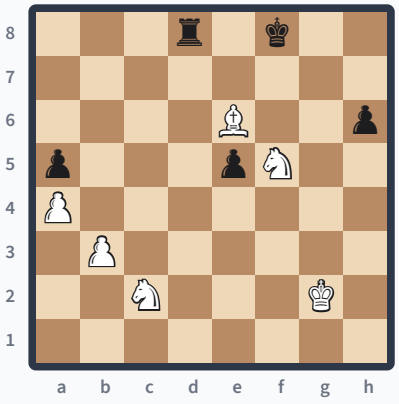
5 **Black is material down. Find the move that holds!**



Topalov v Caruana
7th London Classic 2015

Answer:

6 **Black is material down. Find the move that holds!**



Gelfand v Vallejo Pons
XXVII SuperGM 2010

Answer:

Tip: Kings are fighters in the endgame. Every tempo counts!

Score: ____ / 6

SOLUTIONS

All puzzle answers · Players and event are printed under each puzzle

No peeking
until you've tried!

1. The Isolated Queen's Pawn p. 2

1 28.d5 Qd6 29.Raa1: White is winning (engine +5.0)
2 35.d5 Ne7 36.f3: White is clearly better (engine +2.5)
3 29.d5 Be5 30.Rd1: White is clearly better (engine +1.1)
4 23.d5 Qxd5 24.Bxe4, winning 1 point
5 21...d4 22.Nd1 Bxf3: Black is winning (engine +5.6)
6 46.d5 bxa5 47.bxa5: White is winning (engine +3.4)

2. Hanging Pawns p. 4

1 24.c5 Be7 25.Bf4: White is winning (engine +3.1)
2 15.d5 Ne7 16.d6: White is clearly better (engine +2.1)
3 28...c4 29.Bf1 Rf8: Black is clearly better (engine +1.5)
4 39.d5+ Kc5 40.Ba3+, and mate follows
5 26...d4+ 27.exd4 Nxd3, winning 1 point
6 20...c4 21.Bc2 Bxc2: Black keeps an edge (engine +0.6)

3. Carlsbad Structure & the Minority Attack p. 6

1 17.b4 Bxd3 18.Qxd3: White keeps an edge (engine +0.8)
2 30...Rxa5 31.Rd1 Rxg6, winning 4 points
3 55.Qxh7+ Kg4 56.Qxg6+, and mate follows
4 12.O-O Kh8 13.fxe4, winning 2 points
5 30...Rexf4+ 31.Ke3 Rxf2, winning 2 points
6 46...Rxd1+ 47.Kxd1 h1=Q+: Black is winning (engine +4.9)

4. The Maroczy Bind p. 8

1 36.f5 Rxc1 37.Rxc1, winning 2 points
2 21...b5 22.b4 axb3, winning 1 point
3 17.b5 Bd7 18.Rfa1: White is winning (engine +4.0)
4 20.f5 Nf4 21.Bxf4: White keeps an edge (engine +0.8)
5 12.f4 Ng6 13.e5: White keeps an edge (engine +0.8)
6 24...b5 25.Nc3 Nxc4, winning 1 point

5. The Hedgehog p. 10

1 19...f5 20.Re1 Qg5: Black is clearly better (engine +2.6)
2 37.e5 Rb8 38.exf6, winning 5 points
3 36.g4 Rd6 37.h4: White is clearly better (engine +2.0)
4 33.Nc3 Qe7 34.Bxb6, winning 1 point
5 14.Nd5 Qb7 15.Nxe7+: White is clearly better (engine +1.8)
6 12.Nd5 exd5 13.exd5+: White is clearly better (engine +1.6)

6. The Stonewall p. 12

1 18.f5 Qg8 19.d5: White is winning (engine +4.8)
2 27.Nce5 Rf6 28.Nxf6, winning 2 points
3 30.f5 gxf5 31.Qxf5: White keeps an edge (engine +0.8)
4 32...g5 33.Nd3 Qxh6, winning 1 point
5 18.f5 Bc8 19.e4: White is clearly better (engine +2.5)
6 25.f5 Nf8 26.Rg2: White is clearly better (engine +1.3)

7. King's Indian: Locked Centre p. 14

1 55...gxf4 56.Qa8 Rc7, winning 1 point
2 21.g4 Nf4 22.Qd2: White keeps an edge (engine +0.6)
3 56.bxc5 Nxa5 57.cxd6+: White is clearly better (engine +2.1)
4 37...g2 38.Ka2 axb2: Black is clearly better (engine +1.2)
5 54...g4 55.Qe2 Bh4: Black is clearly better (engine +2.0)
6 66.c8=Q Na3+ 67.Kb3, winning 8 points

8. The Fianchetto p. 16

1 10...h6 11.Bxf6 Qxf6: Black is clearly better (engine +1.4)
2 18...h6 19.Nf3 Nc6: Black keeps an edge (engine +0.4)
3 13.h3 Bxh3 14.Bxh3, winning 1 point
4 25.h3 Be6 26.g4: White is clearly better (engine +2.9)
5 11.h4 Qc7 12.h5: White is clearly better (engine +2.8)
6 13...h5 14.Qg5 Ne2+: Black keeps an edge (engine +0.5)

9. The Pillsbury Knight p. 18

1 16...Nxe5 17.dxe5 Qc7: Black is clearly better (engine +2.9)
2 17...Nf2+ 18.Qxf2 Bxf2, winning 3 points
3 34.Nc4 Qd8 35.Nxa5, winning 5 points
4 34.Nxg6 Qg7 35.Nxf8, winning 6 points
5 41.Rc6 Qxc6 42.Qxf5+: White is winning (engine +4.1)
6 46.Rxf7 Bf1+ 47.Rxf1, winning 4 points

10. Bird's Opening p. 20

1 19.cxd4 Be6 20.dxc5, winning 6 points
2 25.Rxf8+ Kh7 26.Qh5, winning 5 points
3 22...Qxe6 23.Bxg7 Kxg7, winning 5 points
4 18...Qxe3+ 19.Kh1 Qxe4, winning 4 points
5 22...Ng5 23.Qh4 Bxe5, winning 6 points
6 18...Qxf4+ 19.Ke2 Qxe5+, winning 2 points

11. The Exchange Sacrifice p. 22

1 16.Rxc3 Bd7 17.Rb1, winning 3 points
2 20.Rxe6 fxe6 21.Rf3: White is winning (engine +5.3)
3 40...Rxc4 41.Qe5 Rc8, winning 3 points
4 32.Rxd7 Qf8 33.Rf7, winning 3 points
5 27...Rxd6 28.d5 Qc4, winning 3 points
6 54...Rxe3 55.Kxe3 c1=Q+: Black is clearly better (engine +2.2)

12. The Bishop Pair p. 24

1 25.exf6 Qf7 26.fxg7+, winning 2 points
2 14...exd4 15.cxd4 Qa5+, winning 2 points
3 25.fxe4 fxe4 26.Qg2: White keeps an edge (engine +0.9)
4 24.dxe6 Rac8 25.e7, winning 3 points
5 43...d1=Q 44.hxg6+ Kh8, winning 7 points
6 32...hxg5 33.Qxg5 Ba5, winning 2 points

13. Overprotection & Blockade p. 26

1 27...Nf4+ 28.Kd2 Qxg4, winning 3 points
2 31...Ng5 32.Nf5 Rxf5, winning 5 points
3 44.Ne3 Nxg2 45.Rd1: White is clearly better (engine +2.5)
4 19.Nb6 Rxb6 20.Bxb6, winning 1 point
5 37.Ne6+ Rxe6 38.Qxe6, winning 2 points
6 41.Nb3 Bxf2+ 42.Kxf2, winning 1 point

14. Improving Your Worst Piece p. 28

1 22.Nd6 fxe3 23.Nxb7, winning 6 points
2 18.Ba3 d3 19.Nxd3, winning 1 point
3 20.Bf2 Qg6 21.Rxe8: White keeps an edge (engine +0.8)
4 29.Nb6 Rb8 30.Nxc8: White is winning (engine +3.3)
5 27.Ne2 Rh2+ 28.Nxh2: White keeps an edge (engine +0.7)
6 19.Be3 Qd6 20.Bxa8, winning 2 points

15. The Principle of Two Weaknesses p. 30

1 49...a3 50.Ra7 Rxd6, winning 2 points
2 56...e2 57.Bb5+ Ke7, winning 2 points
3 47.Ke5 Bc4 48.fxg6: White keeps an edge (engine +0.5)
4 44...Rc1 45.Bd4 Rxc6, winning 1 point
5 48.g3 Rc4 49.Kxh6, winning 1 point
6 35.Rg4 Rxg4 36.hxg4: White is clearly better (engine +2.5)

16. Space p. 32

1 20.e3 d3 21.Rxd3, winning 1 point
2 15.d5 Ne5 16.Bxh5, winning 3 points
3 17...f3 18.gxf3 Bxf3: Black is winning (engine +4.8)
4 13...e6 14.O-O-O exd5: Black keeps an edge (engine +0.5)
5 25.e5 Nf7 26.exf6: White is winning (engine +3.2)
6 18.e5 Rg8 19.Bxg8, winning 3 points

17. Timing the Central Break p. 34

1 15...d4 16.Re2 Re6: Black keeps an edge (engine +0.9)
2 20...d5 21.Rxd5 Bxb4+, winning 2 points
3 23.e5 Qxe5 24.Bxb7: White keeps an edge (engine +0.8)
4 14.e6 O-O 15.exd7: White keeps an edge (engine +0.5)
5 21...c5 22.Qe1 cxd4: Black keeps an edge (engine +0.6)
6 29.c6 Ne5 30.Rxb7, winning 1 point

18. Pawn Sacrifices for Development p. 36

1 8...g5 9.Nxg5 hxg5: the only move to hold the balance
2 14.d6+ Kf8 15.Qb4: White is clearly better (engine +1.5)
3 10...b5 11.d4 h5: the only move to hold the balance
4 13.e5 a6 14.e6: White is clearly better (engine +1.9)
5 11...d5 12.Rg3 Bg4: Black keeps an edge (engine +0.5)
6 11.d5 Nb8 12.Rb1: White is clearly better (engine +1.2)

19. Evans Gambit p. 38

1 15.Qxa5 Nc2 16.Qc3, winning 3 points
2 24.Rxa1 Re2 25.f3, winning 9 points
3 19.dxe7 Ne5 20.Bxf7+, winning 5 points
4 25.Qf6+ Ke8 26.Qxh8+, winning 5 points
5 24.Nd4 exd4 25.Rxe6, winning 6 points
6 17.Re7+ Qxe7 18.dxe7, winning 4 points

20. Harry the h-Pawn p. 40

1 20.gxh4 Ne5 21.Re1, winning 3 points
2 22...gxh4 23.Bxb5 Rxb5, winning 3 points
3 15...gxh6 16.Ba4 Rb8: Black keeps an edge (engine +0.9)
4 15...h5 16.Bg5 Qxd4, winning 3 points
5 24.gxh5 Bxf2+ 25.Kh1: White is winning (engine +4.9)
6 28.gxh5 Qf3 29.Qc2: White keeps an edge (engine +0.6)

21. Bishop Sacrifices on h7 and g7 p. 42

1 20.Bxg7 Qd3 21.Bxh8, winning 6 points
2 26...Bxg2 27.Rxe7 Qg6: Black is clearly better (engine +2.8)
3 18.Bxh7+ Kxh7 19.Rxd7: White keeps an edge (engine +0.9)
4 37.Bxg7 Kxg7 38.Qg5+: White is winning (engine +4.3)
5 41...Bxg2+ 42.Rxg2 Rxc7, winning 2 points
6 19...Bxg2+ 20.Kxg2 Qg4+, and mate follows

22. Knight Sacrifices on d5, f5 and e6 p. 44

1 13.Nxd5 Bd6 14.Bxd6, winning 1 point
2 28.Nxe6 Rd7 29.Nd8, winning 1 point
3 40.Ne6+ Qxe6 41.Rxe6, winning 1 point
4 27.Ne6 Kh7 28.f4: White is clearly better (engine +2.0)
5 16...Nf4 17.Bc3 Nxe2: Black is clearly better (engine +2.2)
6 30.Ne6+ Bxe6 31.dxe6: White is clearly better (engine +1.3)

23. Rook Endgames: Vancura & Activity p. 46

1 66...Rxg5+ 67.Kf6 Rxd5: the only move to hold the balance
2 48...Rxa3 49.h5 Rxa6, winning 2 points
3 45.Rxh5 fxg3 46.fxg3: the only move to hold the balance
4 28...Rxa3 29.Rb5 h6: the only move to hold the balance
5 41.f6 Kxd5 42.Kf5: White is winning (engine +4.4)
6 41...Rxf3+ 42.Kg2 Rf2+, winning 1 point

24. Opposite-Coloured Bishops p. 48

1 37...g5 38.Kg2 h6: the only move to hold the balance
2 61...Bf5 62.Bd4 Ka3: Black is winning (engine +6.6)
3 65.Bd8 Ka4 66.Kb2: the only move to hold the balance
4 61.a6 Ka4 62.Kc7: White is winning (engine +6.0)
5 41.Bxc7 f5 42.Kf2, winning 1 point
6 36...b2 37.d7 Ke7: Black is winning (engine +3.4)

25. Bishop vs Knight p. 50

1 62.a7 Kc7 63.Nxc4, winning 1 point
2 54.a6 Nd5 55.a7: White is clearly better (engine +2.9)
3 29.Ba7 Nb4 30.Bb8: the only move to hold the balance
4 61.a5 d3 62.Ke3: White is winning (engine +4.5)
5 42.Nc5+ Ka7 43.Kd6: White is clearly better (engine +2.4)
6 41.Bd6 Nf6 42.c5: White is winning (engine +6.5)

26. Fortresses p. 52

1 57.Ne6+ Kf7 58.Nxc7: the only move to hold the balance
2 48.Bd5+ Kf6 49.Bxc4: the only move to hold the balance
3 40...f3+ 41.Kf1 fxg2+: the only move to hold the balance
4 54.Bf7+ Ng6 55.Bxg6+: the only move to hold the balance
5 66...Qe5+ 67.Kb4 Qxe6: the only move to hold the balance
6 36...Rd2+ 37.Kf3 Rxc2: the only move to hold the balance